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«The role of the USA in the transformation of global energy markets: impact on Russia and Russia-EU relations (2008-2024)»

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INTRODUCTION

The **relevance** of this work stems from geopolitical, economic, and environmental dimensions that have shaped global energy dynamics in recent years. The transformation of global energy markets over the past two decades is of particular importance in the context of current tensions between Russia, the European Union, and the United States. This research explores how the United States — through its shale revolution, growing liquefied natural gas (LNG) exports, sanctions policy, energy diplomacy and other implicit and explicit tools — has altered global supply structures and reshaped strategic alignments and dependencies. Examining the impact of these shifts on Russia's complex relationship with the EU, this study demonstrates the intersection of energy security, great power rivalries and domestic decision-making dynamics of states. Understanding the U.S. strategies and their influence on the EU may bring valuable insights to Russian policymakers and shed a light on the future of global energy governance in the developing multipolar world. The European Union (EU) has been an important Russian energy partner for several decades, while also being a close partner of the United States. Given the historically rival nature of Russia-U.S. relations, the U.S. had intentions to prevent close EU-Russia cooperation and integration (except for a short friendly period in 1990s, which was also not characterised by high support of new Russian state developments). Therefore, the factor of U.S. influence has always been present in EU-Russia relations and is of a particular interest given the current Russia-West hybrid war that began after the launch of the Special Military Operation in 2022 (Russian Ministry of Foreign Affairs, 2023). It is very important for Russia to understand the European Union’s independent motivations in combination with the U.S. factor, to be able to develop a substantial foreign policy, especially regarding energy. Nowadays, the U.S. also tries to influence post-Soviet states, which are under strong interest of Russia. These developments support the relevance of understanding U.S. tools and methods

of influence on Russian partners.

The **aim** of this study is to analyze the instruments of the U.S. influence on global energy markets through capturing the combination of tools, including implicit ones, that are not openly promoted, and to assess their influence on energy relations of the EU and Russia.

The **objectives** of the research include assessing the U.S.'s use of key foreign policy instruments in shaping the global energy landscape; exploring historical context of energy in international relations, including the U.S.'s early energy influence; follow and assess the evolution of U.S. energy policy in 2008-2024, particularly the formation of strategies designed to secure energy dominance; examine the strategic shifts in U.S. energy policy, especially in response to key geopolitical events and market changes, such as the shale revolution, the rise of LNG exports, and the U.S.'s increasing role in European energy security. Ultimately, the research seeks to evaluate how these U.S. actions have altered global energy dynamics, with a particular emphasis on the reduction of Russia's influence in European energy markets.

The **object** of this work is the US energy policy and according transformation of the world energy markets, while the **subject** is the impact of the U.S. energy policy on the EU-Russia energy relations.

The **research question** is the following: How did the U.S. impact world energy markets in 2008-2024, and how did this transformation and the US policy influence Russia and EU-Russia relations in the given period? This question allows to address the research gap while being directed on discovering actually useful knowledge and relevant insights into the intersection of energy markets and geopolitics, shedding light on critical shifts in international relations.

It is important to overview and assess the existing knowledge on the topic by conducting a **literature review**. To begin, focus is on the U.S. role in global energy markets and shale revolution. Daniel Yergin in 'The new map: Energy, climate, and

the clash of nations' (2020) offers an account of how the U.S. shale revolution, LNG export surge, and domestic energy policy shifts have reconfigured global energy flows. He claims that energy self-sufficiency underpinned American strategic confidence, even as Biden-era policies created tension between climate goals and fossil fuel dominance. Yergin also argues that Russia's energy leverage in Europe has been undermined by diversification and sanctions but this was a point of internal growth and new partnerships. Yergin also provides a good historical account of development of energy assets as political ones in 'The prize: The epic quest for oil, money, and power' (1991). Aguilera and Radetzki (2014) provide a macroeconomic and geopolitical account of the U.S. shale revolution's transformative impact on global energy markets. They emphasize that technological breakthroughs allowed the U.S. to dramatically increase natural gas and oil production between 2005 and 2013, overtaking Russia as the world's largest gas producer by 2009. The article links U.S. shale expansion to shifting global gas trade patterns, the emergence of LNG export capacity, and downward pressure on gas prices, which has weakened Russia's pricing power in Europe: Gazprom was forced to renegotiate long-term contracts due to more competitive spot pricing catalyzed by redirected U.S. LNG. Blackwill and O'Sullivan (2014) also argue that the shale revolution enabled the USA to weaken Russia as a producer by helping European allies negotiate better terms with Gazprom. The authors highlight that Washington began using energy policy strategically — linking LNG export approvals to foreign policy objectives and launching diplomatic tools like the Energy Governance and Capacity Initiative. O'Sullivan (2017) points to positive consequences of 'the new energy abundance' — as a possibility for the USA and China to decrease conflict and cooperate on energy terms. Andreas (2015) demonstrates that the shale revolution gave the USA enormous advantage and changed global energy competition. Sargsyan (2022) shows how U.S. external energy policy operationalizes energy security through diversified diplomacy. He emphasizes the spatial dimension of U.S. energy engagement, with different instruments across

developed (e.g., EU, Japan) and resource-rich developing regions (e.g., Africa, Latin America). Particularly relevant is his classification of direct tools (LNG exports, sanctions, technology transfer) and indirect tools (legislative assistance, governance support, energy diplomacy). Davtyan (2018) analyzes how the U.S. pursuit of energy dominance under Trump aimed to displace Russian influence, particularly via LNG exports and sanctions. However, he argues that high costs, infrastructure gaps, and market realities limited U.S. ambitions, especially in Europe where Russian gas remained competitive. Khlopov (2019) analyzed the internal contradictions in the Trump administration's energy dominance strategy, highlighting how expanded fossil fuel production was prioritized as a tool of foreign policy and national security. The article provides a useful contrast between Trump's geopolitical use of shale and LNG exports and domestic resistance from environmental and progressive forces advocating for the Green New Deal. While acknowledging the geopolitical gains of becoming a net exporter, Khlopov underscores that long-term U.S. energy leadership may depend more on innovation in renewables than fossil fuels. However, many of the existing books and articles lost their relevance due to new geopolitical shifts and subsequent energy market dynamics. There is a need for more modern research to account for these new factors.

Then there is literature on the history of energy relations between Russia and the EU. Stern (2006) provides a good historical background of energy conditions in Europe and claims that energy cooperation between Russia and the European Union was rising for decades, leading to the increase of interdependence, and mutually beneficial trade conditions. Gustafson (2020) presents a detailed historical and institutional analysis of the 'gas bridge' between Russia and Europe, tracing its evolution from Cold War cooperation to a fragile and politicized structure in the 21st century. He shows how natural gas trade stabilized East–West relations through long-term contracts, but also how the EU's liberalization and decarbonization efforts have weakened this system. While Gazprom acted largely commercially in Western

Europe, Gustafson argues that in Central and Eastern Europe, gas was wielded as a geopolitical instrument. The breakdown of mutual trust and the EU's shift toward market-based governance now threaten the bridge's stability, making its dismantling both geopolitically risky and structurally difficult. Boris Barkanov has examined the geo-economic strategies employed by Russia, particularly through Gazprom, to maintain its influence over European energy markets, showing that integration was mutually desirable (Barkanov, 2018). However, cooperative incentives have slowly declined in the EU. Gas crises pushed the transition to renewable energy and general EU concerns about Russia. Siddi (2022) explores several Ukrainian crises and their influence on making EU-Russia relations more sensitive. The author also assesses energy cooperation as beneficial for both parties, but constantly undermined by political concerns.

Finally, the literature on the U.S.-EU relations will be useful. Smith (2021) shows the dependent position of the EU under the USA. He identifies it as a subaltern role of the EU where it acts as a channel for U.S. policies and preferences, particularly in areas like security and economic organization. This suggests a level of dependence on U.S. decisions. Smith and Steffenson (2023) in 'The EU and the USA: Competitive Cooperation in. International Relations and the European Union' suggest deep historical ties in the Transatlantic community which stems from the beginning of European cooperation, described as US-driven with aims of contrasting the Soviet communist bloc. In modern context such basis for historical ties may be reflected in current actions of these actors. Moreover, Kirshner (2014) shows major interconnectedness of the United States and the European Union, illustrating implications of economic distress in Europe on U.S. financial stability and strategic interests, so the economy of the European Union has always been crucially important for the U.S. Despite a strong foundation of shared values and institutional cooperation, Cuciurianu (2014) emphasizes that the U.S.-EU relationship remains defined by 'competitive cooperation': regulatory, economic, and geopolitical

divergences (particularly in trade liberalization, energy governance, and crisis management) have created overlapping but sometimes conflicting agendas. The TTIP negotiations, while framed as a unifying project, revealed underlying competition over market access, regulatory standards, and global influence. Thus, although the U.S. and EU maintain a partnership for mutual strategic benefit, they are not driven solely by full dominance of the U.S. and blind integration in all terms.

However, there are not many studies addressing in particular the U.S. role in energy markets and its influence on Russia and EU cooperation with Russia in the energy sphere. There is extensive research on the U.S. foreign policy, on the formation of global energy markets, external power projection of the United States, on the European Union, literature assessing EU-Russia energy relations, dependency, securitisation and evolution. Despite this, there remains a significant **research gap** as there is no comprehensive study that would combine these factors together to show how in fact the presence of the U.S. shaped energy markets and Russia-EU relations in particular in a given period and how this process has unfold. While many studies have focused on the broader geopolitical implications of U.S. sanctions and diplomatic efforts, less attention has been paid to how these external pressures are balanced with the EU's strategic interests. Moreover, the impact of current hybrid warfare (after 2022) has not been thoroughly explored in existing literature. Therefore, this study fills this research gap, examining specific mechanisms through which U.S. influence was projected on energy markets and how it has shaped EU energy policies, taking into account both external and internal factors.

The **timeframe** of the study is the period from 2008 to 2024 — beginning with shale revolution in the USA and capturing presidencies of Bush Jr. (one year in 2008), Obama, Trump and Biden in the U.S. and three crises in EU-Russia relations (2009, 2014, 2022[1] , as well as consequences of the 2008 economic crisis and global energy

[1] 2009 crisis — Russia-Ukraine dispute over gas prices and unpaid debts, when Russia cut off gas supplies to Ukraine, affecting gas delivery to several European countries for nearly two weeks; 2014 crisis — Crimean referendum and

crisis related to the pandemic. This timeframe allows to show change of U.S. energy policy through times of these crises.

The **hypothesis** is the following: A combination of soft and hard power instruments in the US foreign policy and energy strategy supported the EU's shift from cooperation with Russia to diversification of energy supplies, securitization of Russian energy and demonization of Russia as a whole, and to eventual change in relations with Russian Pivot to Asia and EU turn to imports of U.S LNG, from which the USA benefited the most. But the U.S. influence was not a primary deterministic one — own interests of the European Union and lack of unified internal opinion also matter.

The **methodology** is constructed to allow for comprehensive analysis of all necessary factors, combining qualitative and quantitative methods to catch underlying political and strategic narratives, while also providing enough statistical empirical evidence. International relations theories of neoclassical realism, neoliberalism and constructivism will also be provided as frameworks for analysis.

Regarding the theoretical framework, in this research neoclassical realism, constructivism (securitization theory), and neoliberalism (complex interdependence) theories are used. Neoclassical realism is best to explain foreign policies of the USA and the EU, as it focuses on the interplay between the international system's pressures and domestic factors in shaping an actor's behavior[2]. Unlike classical realism, that does not pay any attention to internal processes within state, and sees the world as an arena of wars due to human nature, and structural realism that sees reasons of wars in changes of balance of power, neoclassical realism is also looking inside the state, with broadened view on domestic processes which is extremely important in the case of the U.S. and the EU policy formation and development of state behavior. This shows how

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reunification with Russia was severely condemned by the EU; 2022 — Russia-Ukraine crisis also followed by EU accusations of Russia as an aggressor.

[2] Rose, G. (1998). Neoclassical realism and theories of foreign policy. World Politics, 51(1), 144–172

EU member states balance external threats with domestic political priorities, leading to a better understanding of the EU's energy policy evolution. The U.S. foreign policy formulation and implementation is also a combination of domestic pressures and needs and the defence of national interest. Constructivism allows better exploring how U.S. narratives, discourses and personalities have shaped the energy market and EU perceptions of Russia as well as the EU shaped it. This adds depth by showing how ideational factors, identity, norms, perceptions and narratives shaped energy relations in construction of reality — not just material interests. Securitization theory, being a part of a Copenhagen school of IR and of the constructivist paradigm, helps to illustrate how the U.S. has framed Russia as a security threat, influencing EU discourse and policy and how this process unfolded with particular extraordinary measures used and how in fact energy is framed as a security threat. Finally, complex interdependence theory, which is a part of neoliberal paradigm, allows to demonstrate and explain deep economic ties between Russia and the EU, where mutual energy dependence created both cooperation and vulnerability. It also captures how the U.S. influence worked through markets and economies. Together these theories offer a comprehensive lens to understand both strategic behavior and evolving threat perceptions in the U.S.-Russia-EU energy dynamics.

As for the methods, this research uses a mixed-method approach. Qualitative methods of discourse and content analysis are used to collect and analyse non-numerical data with deduction, induction and synthesis. And quantitative descriptive statistical analysis will be used to assess numerical data and statistical evidence. To assess the narrative and propaganda efforts by the U.S., the work will analyze public statements with discourse analysis. This method allows to see how key actors communicate meanings around energy and security, especially in moments of crisis and tension. Analysis of written and spoken language of decision-makers and influential officials, speeches and official statements of the U.S. representatives is helpful to analyse their tools and techniques to reveal how Russia was portrayed and

how it was translated and accepted by the EU. The study explores implicit mechanisms and the role of publicly available information in shaping perceptions and policy directions. It is possible to reveal how the U.S. LNG was framed as 'freedom gas' and Russian as 'evil' and coercion. This is useful combined with the framework of securitization theory to follow the ways in which language was used to bring attention to the issue of energy dependency and justify reaction.

Quantitative methods aim to assess EU-Russia, EU-U.S. energy trade data, with a focus on LNG imports — analysis of trade volumes, trends, and shifts in energy supply sources. Descriptive statistical analysis of changes in trade volumes and prices of different energy types serves to identify patterns between U.S. policy shifts and changes in energy markets, in the EU in particular. Sanctions data is used to evaluate their impact on Russian energy exports and EU energy imports — with a focus on changes in supply and the effectiveness of sanctions and their implications for EU energy security (in particular in times of 2014 and 2022 Ukraine crises are analysed to reveal external shocks' role and U.S. influence). Statistical methods are important for providing credible empirical evidence for key trends and shifts, reinforcing qualitative findings. The radar chart is then employed to visually capture and compare multiple dimensions of U.S. energy policies and their impacts on global energy markets. Instruments revealed are assigned weights (thus, their importance is quantified) and then compared with radar chart visualization. This enables the comparison of multiple variables in a structured, measurable way.

For such analysis it is important to choose primary sources that would allow for comprehensive understanding of dynamics of interest. The empirical basis for this work includes:

- Official governmental documents of the U.S.: All press releases, media notes, fact sheets, briefing papers, remarks of U.S. officials and departments published by the U.S. Department of State, and U.S. Congress and Department of Energy

between 2008 and 2024, where Russia, energy, oil, gas and other related topics are mentioned (such as U.S.-EU joint statements and U.S. energy policy reports on LNG exports) — crucial to follow the change in discourse and in general interest in the topic, changing alliances and partnership agreements. Statements of Presidents Barack Obama, Donald Trump and Joe Biden, as well as Secretaries of State Hillary Clinton, John Kerry, Michael R. Pompeo and Antony J. Blinken are assessed.

- Official documents of the EU: The European Commission, the European Council and the Council of the EU papers published in the period of interest that are related to Russia and energy strategies. Such as REPowerEU, Energy Union Plan, Energy targets for 2040 and statements of EU officials (Josep Borrell, Ursula von der Leyen, Federica Mogherini).
- To a lesser extent, representations of speeches and events in media organizations like Reuters and CNBC.
- Statistics and industry reports: Reports from the U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA) and documents from international bodies such as the International Energy Agency (IEA), Eurostat, Oxford Institute for Energy Studies and the European Union provide helpful extensive quantitative and qualitative data that help in understanding the economic dimensions of energy market changes.

The research is expected to reveal that ultimately, the U.S. finds itself in the most advantageous position and with highest profit from contemporary changes in energy market dynamics. The U.S. strategically used energy sources as a tool for maintaining power and to benefit from it in times of crises and opening of new markets that allow high penetration and opportunities for high economic profit with improved political image. Since the U.S. shale revolution, American LNG became a viable alternative to Russian gas in Europe, but it was only under the Trump administration that the United States began actively promoting its LNG exports to the

EU. The outbreak of Russian Special Military Operation in Ukraine and the resulting hybrid war with the West forced the European Union to sharply reduce imports of Russian gas and increase reliance on U.S. LNG — a shift the United States strongly encouraged. However, American influence, while significant, was not the primary determinant of EU energy policy. Prior to the war, despite repeated U.S. calls to abandon Russian gas, key EU member states such as Germany prioritized their own strategic and economic interests. Moreover, there was no unified position within the EU itself regarding energy dependence on Russia.

The boundaries of this research are defined by several key limitations. Firstly, the study primarily relies on publicly accessible official sources, and some information could be not openly disclosed. While publicly available documents, such as press releases and official statements, provide valuable insights, they often reflect official narratives, potentially limiting the depth of analysis. Field research and practical observation of the work of departments of interest is not possible, due to the very nature of the IR sphere, thus, only online search for accessible information is possible, which may limit the basis for analysis. Moreover, geopolitical complexities and shifting international alliances may affect the consistency of energy policies, making it difficult to predict long-term trends and account for additional external factors that influenced the EU, Russia and global markets.

The **structure** of this research is the following: first chapter provides an introduction into the importance and global significance of energy as a material resource and political leverage, then there will be historical background of the U.S. presence on global energy markets as a major importer, followed by explanation of the U.S. energy policy formulation.

Second chapter assesses the United States presence on energy markets from a theoretical standpoint — combining different IR theories to explain aspects of U.S. actions, as well as the EU securitization of energy dependence on Russia. Third

chapter is dedicated to in-depth discourse and content analysis in chronological order. Thus, evolution of methods, instruments and mechanisms of U.S. influence on energy markets is analyzed and presented in a table and a radar chart. The fourth, and final chapter aims to assess the current situation around Russia-EU relations and the point from which Russian Pivot to Asia starts with future implications and policy recommendations for related actors. Thus, the work combines several methods and theoretical frameworks to conduct a deep analysis of the role of the USA in the transformation of global energy markets and its impact on Russia and Russia-EU relations.

CHAPTER 1: THE HISTORY OF THE IMPORTANCE OF ENERGY AND THE U.S. ENERGY INFLUENCE

Oil is often described as the 'blood of the war', 'blood of the earth' and the 'lifeblood of victory'. These metaphors stand on the basis of oil being a reason for many wars, economic competitions, main resource for war, economy of every state and the most tradeable asset in the world[3] due to its pivotal role in powering industries, transportation, and electricity generation (OEC, 2023). Throughout the history of the modern era, energy resources, and above all oil, have shaped not only economic development but also the strategic calculus of great powers. From WWII to the Cold War and contemporary Arctic race, the quest for energy shaped alliances, triggered conflicts, and reshaped geopolitical boundaries. This chapter will introduce foundations of the importance of energy and its leverage as a tool of power with subsequent historical overview of the usage of this leverage by the USA.

1.1 The Role of Energy in International Relations

Collectively, National Oil Companies control approximately 90% of the world's proven oil reserves[4] (Visualizing Energy, 2024). Every state in the world needs energy to survive and to be economically competitive. That is why it is so desirable for powerful states, such as the USA, to maintain and develop influence in the world energy market. Russia is a valuable player in this arena, being the second top crude oil and natural gas liquids exporter since 1997, after Saudi Arabia[5] (IEA, 2021). In 2023 Russian production of oil accounted for 11% of world total production, twice less than the U.S. one[6] (EIA, 2024). In general, the United States, Russia and Saudi Arabia can be considered to be the most powerful energy producers in the world. This creates

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[3] Observatory of Economic Complexity. (2023). World profile. https://oec.world/en/profile/world/wld

[4] Visualizing Energy. (June 10, 2024). Where are the world's most valuable oil and gas companies? Retrieved from https://visualizingenergy.org/where-are-the-worlds-most-valuable-oil-and-gas-companies/

[5] International Energy Agency. (July 30, 2021). World top crude and NGL exporters (1997-2019). Retrieved from https://www.iea.org/data-and-statistics/charts/world-top-crude-and-ngl-exporters-1997-2019

[6] U.S. Energy Information Administration. (April 11, 2024). How much carbon dioxide is produced from burning gasoline and diesel fuel? Retrieved from https://www.eia.gov/tools/faqs/faq.php?id=709&t=6

ground for competition for sales markets, which is evident in Russia-U.S. activities on the European gas market, especially since 2022, when Russian supplies were significantly cut and the U.S. appeared to be the largest LNG exporter to the EU, previously the most important Russian energy partner and largest market for Russian energy supplies.

Energy sources are central to global politics and are not only an economic tool and a valuable asset in practical terms, but also a strategic asset. Control over energy resources, access to them and their distribution is a source of conflicts, wars, alliances and power hierarchies. Oil embargoes of the 1970s, Russia-Ukraine gas disputes (2006, 2009, 2014, 2022), China's energy diplomacy through BRI initiative, and current U.S. post-2008 LNG diplomacy and sanctions against Iran oil sector illustrate how energy is for a long time used as a strategic tool and in some cases coercively as a weapon. Blondeel et al. (2021) argue that nations controlling vast reserves of fossil fuels or strategic infrastructure are able to leverage their position to secure geopolitical advantages, while those without such control are at risk. However, it is not the case that all states with vast energy sources are capable of projecting power from it. Poor countries with no opportunities to develop infrastructure may become victims of exploitation by more powerful states. Nigeria is an example. It has vast reserves of oil but is not able to effectively extract it, which brings attention of Western companies to the region. Thus, despite being Africa's largest oil producer, Nigeria has long been exploited by, for example, U.S.'s Chevron and ExxonMobil, leading to environmental degradation, human rights abuses and finally the state receiving less money than foreign companies (Martial, 2025). Factor of obtaining energy reserves is not enough to be able to use it strategically. Energy markets must not be considered solely as economic domains but as politically contested ones where state and non-state actors are having strategic interests, projecting power, and challenging orders.

Energy and geopolitics

Geopolitics is the study of the influence of geographical factors on politics and behavior of states. But there is also a more specific concept — geopolitics of global energy security, which, according to Bradshaw (2009, p. 1920), is the "influence of geographical factors, such as the distribution of centres of supply and demand, on state and non-state actions to ensure adequate, affordable and reliable supplies of energy"[7]. Energy links physical geography to world power dynamics. Supply and demand in the international energy system are unevenly distributed, and production is regionalized in politically sensitive regions like the Middle East, post-Soviet states and Africa, while demand is high in industrialized and rapidly developing economies. Control of key oil and gas reserves, or influence over chokepoints like the Strait of Hormuz or key pipeline routes in Eurasia, enhances ability to project power or create dependencies, particularly in energy-importing areas. Thus, importer states are concerned with securing supply chains, which increases the importance of energy corridors, and transit states (Bradshaw, 2009, p. 1921). Geography, therefore, does not merely constrain energy flows — it dictates who exercises power in the global energy order. Thus, Russian-European pipelines and transit states, especially Ukraine, are politically contested areas where security, economic interest and bargaining meet.

Oil has long been (and will continue to be) one of the fundamental causes of geopolitical conflict, particularly in politically volatile but resource-abundant territories. Though oil was an emerging factor in early 20th-century conflict, in World War II its strategic importance became highly present — powering mechanized armies, air power, and navies required energy to function. Klare warns that the US presence in the Persian Gulf, the Caspian, and Central Asia, particularly following 9/11 interventions, is intimately linked with energy security imperatives and access to oil shipping routes. More broadly, the central place of oil in the global economy

[7] Bradshaw, M. (2009). The geopolitics of global energy security. Geography Compass, 3(5), 1920–1937

makes it a chronic cause of conflict (Klare, 2002). This is in fact true regarding modern international conflict developments. From the US invasion of Iraq, often explained through expression of strategic interest in accessing oil reserves, to civil wars in Libya and South Sudan, where conflicting forces fighted for access to oil. Mineral resources may fund armed aggression and become bargaining chips. Some authors and Western media even claim access to Ukrainian coal deposits located in Donbas to be a critical factor of the 2022 Russia-initiated Special Military Operation in Ukraine (Muggah, 2025; Polityuk, 2024). This demonstrates that energy sources are a perpetual source of power struggles.

The Second World War marked the first full-scale global conflict in which oil appeared to be the indispensable fuel of war, central to both strategy and logistics. Access to petroleum became a key determinant of military mobility and industrial resilience. Both Japan and Germany launched campaigns to power their war machines. Japan, whose economy was heavily dependent on U.S. imports of oil before the war (in the late 1930s, 80% came from the U.S.)[8], viewed American embargoes in 1941 as an immediate threat to national survival and invaded Pearl Harbor to guarantee alternative supply from the Dutch East Indies (Yergin, 1991, pp. 314). Similarly, German war economy relied on synthetic fuels, this was the reason for the Nazi drive into the Soviet Union during 1941 — particularly towards the Caucasus region — to seize the Baku oil fields since Germany's synthetic fuel production and Romanian imports were insufficient for a protracted conflict (Yergin, 1991, pp. 334). Hitler's 1942 campaign (Operation Blau) prioritized capturing Baku's oil over taking Moscow, highlighting fuel's pivotal role in German war planning. Finally, fuel shortages undermined the effectiveness of Axis operations and Blitzkrieg's momentum, harming mobility and aviation. While the U.S., being petroleum-rich and rapidly industrializing, emerged as the world's largest producer of

[8] Yergin, D. (1991). The prize: The epic quest for oil, money, and power (p. 307). Simon & Schuster.

military gasoline — enabling the Allied side to continue operating on both the European and Pacific fronts (Yergin, 1991, pp. 371). Thus, ability to obtain and use oil emerged as a structural determinant of World War II victory or defeat.

The 1973 oil crisis appeared to be a milestone change in world's energy, brought by OAPEC (Organization of Arab Petroleum Exporting Countries) members that imposed a ban on oil exports to the U.S. in retaliation for US support for Israel during the Yom Kippur War. Reduction of oil shipments and production rates hurt the United States. It raised major concerns about energy dependency, revealed the U.S.'s vulnerability as a net oil importer, and politicized oil for the first time on a global scale. It led to quadrupling the price of oil inflicting a shock in inflation, industrial slow-down, and recession (Bradshaw, 2009, p. 1924). The crisis induced institutionalization of strategic petroleum reserves, the establishment of the International Energy Agency, and the move of energy policy to the national interest level in the USA. These developments illustrate that energy has functioned as a central axis of geopolitical strategy and conflict, making control over resources, transit routes, and supply security a defining feature of international power dynamics and foreign policy behavior for years.

Energy as economic leverage and tool of political pressure

As it can be seen, the control of supply routes and price manipulations mechanisms are strong instruments of influencing behavior of states in the international arena. Russia's gas supply disruptions[9] are seen by some authors as examples of use of power and energy as a weapon (Stern, 2006, pp. 10-11). These disruptions influenced Ukraine's energy security and EU's downstream concerns, illustrating how interdependence can be strategically exploited. This pattern of behavior reflects a realist logic where energy becomes a tool of coercion within asymmetric interdependencies. In addition to coercion, energy is a significant

[9] 2006 and 2009 gas crises when Russia cut off supplies to Ukraine, causing gas shortages in Europe

instrument of 'resource diplomacy' — diplomatic utilization of energy commerce, investment, and infrastructure to deepen friendships and expand geopolitical influence. China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), for example, includes massive energy infrastructure projects such as pipelines, ports, and electricity grids across Asia and Africa designed to ensure long-term supply and support political ties. Energy sector was the biggest in investments in early years, making five Chinese construction companies the largest globally, including PowerChina (focused on construction of energy infrastructure) (IISS, 2022). With similar logic, the United States has promoted its liquefied natural gas exports as both an economic opportunity and a geopolitical alternative to Russian gas in Europe, especially under the Trump and Biden administrations. Thus, energy also functions as a diplomatic tool supporting broader strategic objectives. Sanctions targeting energy sectors are a very common feature of the U.S. foreign policy and are used to weaken adversaries by restricting their access to global markets and technological resources. The U.S. has imposed sweeping energy sanctions on oil-producing countries such as Iran, Venezuela, and Russia in order to limit state revenues funding strategic or military activities. United States and European Union sanctions on Iranian crude oil exports caused Iran's oil exports to decline by approximately 50% by 2014[10], reducing government revenues by billions of dollars each year and placing extreme fiscal pressure on Iran that helped drive Iran to the negotiating table, culminating in the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) in 2015, aimed at limiting Iranian nuclear program.

This proves the ability and utility of using energy sanctions as elements of coercive diplomacy. However, this is not what can be said about U.S. and EU sanctions against Russia following the 2022 special military operation in Ukraine which targeted both crude oil and natural gas technologies, aiming to erode Moscow's long-term capacity to fund the 'war' and maintain its dominance in European energy

[10] U.S. Energy Information Administration. (2015, June 24). Under sanctions, Iran's crude oil exports have nearly halved in three years. https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=21792

markets. These measures were designed to reduce the Kremlin's hydrocarbon revenues — which constituted 45%[11] of federal budget income prior to the conflict (IEA, 2022) — and to undermine Russia's long-term capacity to finance its military operations and sustain its dominant position in the European energy market (European Council, 2025). Overall effectiveness of these sanctions is not clear, they did not stop the conflict and did not undermine Russia as a powerful state, despite lowering the respect of Western countries. This gave Russia the opportunity to develop internal production and technologies, find new trade partners and develop previous partnerships. However, EU energy imports from Russia have indeed lowered. Data from the Council of the European Union (2025) reveals a significant decrease in EU's reliance on Russian natural gas with its share in EU imports dropping from over 40% in 2021 to about 11% in 2024[12]. And U.S. supplies of LNG doubled from 2021[13] being equal to 45%[14] of total LNG imports in the EU in 2024. Therefore, these sanctions reflect the integration of energy into broader coercive strategies in international relations, being both the aim and the instrument.

Main energy sources overview

Energy transitions refer to global shifts in dominant energy sources with the aim to use the most efficient ones. According to Smil (2017, p. 395), there have been three main energy transitions in history: coal replacing wood in the 19th century Industrial Revolution due to steam engines and urbanization, then from coal to oil in the 20th century due to development of automobiles and mechanized warfare, then from oil to natural gas driven by its utilization for cooking, heating and maritime transportation since it is cleaner burning fuel than coal and oil. Introduction of nuclear

[11] International Energy Agency. (2022, March 21). Energy fact sheet: Why does Russian oil and gas matter? https://www.iea.org/articles/energy-fact-sheet-why-does-russian-oil-and-gas-matter

[12] Council of the European Union. (2025, May 8). Where does the EU's gas come from? https://www.consilium.europa.eu/en/infographics/where-does-the-eu-s-gas-come-from/

[13] European Commission. (2022). EU-U.S. LNG trade: U.S. liquefied natural gas (LNG) has the potential to help match EU gas needs. https://energy.ec.europa.eu/system/files/2022-02/EU-US_LNG%20trade_2022.pdf

[14] European Commission. (2024). Liquefied natural gas. https://energy.ec.europa.eu/topics/carbon-management-and-fossil-fuels/liquefied-natural-gas_en

power usage in WWII as a source of stable base-load electric generation with zero direct carbon emissions has also altered the world's total primary energy consumption. Today we stand on the next step: transition from fossil fuels to low-carbon energy renewables (solar, wind and hydropower) pushed by ideological commitment to climate change mitigation and political agendas. This transition differs from previous ones in the fact that it is more politicized and driven primarily not by efficiency (as these are costly and more risky energy sources) but more by political considerations and international agreements. Despite rising interest in renewables (especially in the EU in context of energy dependency reduction), fossil fuels (oil, coal, natural gas) accounted for 80% of global energy demand in 2023[15] (IEA, 2024, p. 24). Relative significance of various energy sources has changed considerably: oil remains the most internationally traded commodity worldwide, primarily fueling the transportation sector (IEA, 2024, p. 19). Coal's share of primary energy has been in structural decline since 2008, but it is still extensively used for electricity production[16] (with China and India being largest consumers) (IEA, 2024). Natural gas is extensively used for electricity generation and heating and became more important as a 'transition fuel' (IEA, 2024, p. 24) replacing coal due to lower carbon emissions. In 2023 the USA became the largest LNG producer in the world and also produced more crude oil this year than every country did before (IEA, 2024, p. 250). Thus, with geopolitical disturbances after 2022, which accelerated the shift away from Russian hydrocarbons in Europe and enhanced investment in renewables and LNG infrastructure, the United States reaffirmed itself as a global energy supplier.

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[15] International Energy Agency. (2024). World Energy Outlook 2024. Paris: IEA. https://www.iea.org/reports/world-energy-outlook-2024

[16] International Energy Agency. (2024). Coal 2024: Analysis and forecast to 2026. Paris: IEA. https://www.iea.org/reports/coal-2024

1.2 The U.S. in Global Energy Markets: An Overview (Pre-2008 Context)

It is important to briefly outline the role of the United States in global energy markets prior to 2008 to understand patterns that were present historically in the behavior of the state. The history of high penetration of the U.S. in world energy markets begins with the creation of the petrodollar system. In general, the energy path of the country was shaped by a long-standing dependence on foreign oil and strategic energy policymaking. Early energy policies, both domestic and foreign, had aims of securing access to resources and stabilizing markets, rooting energy deeply in U.S. foreign policy making.

1970s oil crisis and the establishment of petrodollar system

The first oil well in the USA, 21 meters deep, was drilled in Pennsylvania in 1859, according to the Higher School of Innovative Business of MSU. It had a production capacity of 15 barrels of oil per day. In 1870 John D. Rockefeller founded the Standard Oil Company and became the richest man of all time with a highly effective vertical integration strategy and full control over the supply chain. By 1973 'Seven Sisters' — mainly American major oil companies[17] controlled 85% of all extracted oil in the Earth[18]. The Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) was created in 1960 — as a response to growing Western multinational oil company dominance over oil prices and production. The majors dominated the oil market and determined prices while countries-producers of oil had little access to their resources and revenues. Discontented with this inability to control their oil resources, five founding members — oil-exporting nations — decided to unite to protect their economic interests (OPEC, n.d.). The OPEC attempted to reduce dependence on Western oil companies and enhance the negotiating power of member states. Their

[17] Esso Petroleum, Standard Oil of New York (later Mobil), Standard Oil of California (later Chevron), Texaco, Royal Dutch Shell, and British Petroleum

[18] Oil and Gas Courses. (n.d.). The new seven supermajor oil companies. https://oilandgascourses.org/the-new-seven-supermajor-oil-companies/

success was evident during the 1973 oil crisis, when OPEC reduced oil production to increase oil prices under anti-Western political objectives. The 1970s were a turning point for global energy markets. Following the 1973 oil crisis, the U.S. entered an agreement with Saudi Arabia to denominate oil sales in U.S. dollars. This was a signal of the establishment of the petrodollar system, backing the dollar's dominance of international markets and ensuring U.S. economic influence across the globe. It is important to trace back to the Bretton Woods system, which collapsed in 1971. It was agreed in 1944 and brought the return of the Gold Standard — pegged the U.S. dollar to gold and the other currencies to the dollar. U.S. fiscal policy, particularly financing military for the war in Vietnam and domestic social welfare programs, created increasing inflation and a sharp reduction in the U.S. gold reserves by the late 1960s. President Nixon, in August 1971, announced that convertibility of the dollar to gold had to be suspended, which marked the end of the Bretton Woods system. This provoked global uncertainty over the worth of the dollar and its status as world currency. The dollar needed another device by which to still control world demand. That device was oil.

Massive geopolitical crisis in October 1973 was provoked after the Yom Kippur War — between Israel (supported by the USA) and a coalition of Arab states, primarily Egypt and Syria. OAPEC members imposed an oil embargo on the United States and allies for support of Israel (Reich, 1995). Due to reduced supply options and stable demand, oil prices rose from $3 before the crisis to over $11 a barrel in January 1974, causing a global recession (Merrill, 2007). For the United States, the crisis was a turning point that confirmed the strategic importance of controlling energy resources and protecting the dollar's hegemony. In 1974, the U.S. made a historic agreement with Saudi Arabia — the world's top oil producer — on which the petrodollar system was based. Negotiated by Henry Kissinger, this secret deal required Saudi Arabia to sell oil in American dollars alone. The oil-exporting

countries' dollar surpluses were invested in U.S. government bonds, financial markets, and infrastructure. In exchange for payment, the U.S. guaranteed Saudi Arabia and other Gulf states political stability and military protection. This treaty provided the United States with a series of significant benefits. Countries around the globe needed dollars to purchase oil, making the dollar the world reserve currency. Recycling petrodollars back into the United States provided it with a steady capital inflow to use in financing trade deficits and defense. The U.S. also secured substantial control over international oil markets and OPEC policy. As a result of the oil crisis, Congress created the Strategic Petroleum Reserve (SPR) in 1975 as insurance against future supply disruption. It was an emergency source of oil to mitigate the impact of future supply shocks that enhanced U.S. negotiating leverage by serving as a buffer against external supply pressure. It also helped stabilize world markets by selling oil during periods of high price volatility. The SPR was designed to store up to 1 billion barrels of crude oil in Gulf Coast salt caverns. Although it never approached operation at full capacity, it was a key component of U.S. energy security. In contrast, the International Energy Agency (IEA) was created in 1974 and consisted of 31 states representing 75% of global energy consumption (IEA, n.d.). Organization aimed to coordinate energy policies among major oil-consuming nations and make them less vulnerable to supply shocks. The IEA provided reliable information and forecasts regarding global energy markets and helped member countries to reduce dependence on foreign oil and adopt more sustainable energy policies. During this period, the Soviet Union was also a significant oil exporter, but the emergence of the petrodollar system limited its ability to bypass Western financial institutions. The growing involvement of the U.S. in global energy markets set the stage for future competition between the two superpowers.

The petrodollar system solidified the dollar position in international trade, and it became the de facto global reserve currency. Oil-importing countries became

dollar-reserve dependent, and subjected to currency risks and U.S. monetary policy. For the Soviet Union, U.S. dollar supremacy in global energy markets proved to be a challenge. These weaknesses became more pronounced in the 1980s and set the stage for competition in the future between Russia and the U.S. in global energy markets, particularly in Europe.

The 1990s and early 2000s: episodic engagement

These years witnessed episodic U.S. engagement in the energy sector, driven largely by geopolitical considerations. The collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 proved the U.S. to remain the only superpower in the international arena. This position required more active policies, and a shift in foreign focus from containment of communism to securing global energy resources and ensuring regional stability in key oil-producing areas. The Gulf War (1990-1991) was an example of how energy and military intervention were interconnected. The war was triggered by Iraq's invasion of Kuwait — Iraq gained control of approximately 20% of the world's oil reserves, raising concerns about global energy security (History, 2024). The U.S., at the head of a coalition of countries in Operation Desert Storm, quickly drove out Iraqi troops and restored Kuwaiti sovereignty. Objective was to prevent Iraq from monopolizing the Gulf's oil supply, which could give it significant leverage over global markets. The intervention reinforced the U.S. commitment to maintaining security in the Gulf region and protecting its energy interests, strengthening military alliances and making permanent U.S. military bases in the region. It also allowed American oil majors to expand their influence in the region, particularly in Saudi Arabia and Kuwait (Klare, 2004). The U.S. also gained control over regional politics, using its presence to contain Iraq and dictate strategic direction of key oil-producing nations, securing its hegemony over world energy and regional geopolitics for future decades. There was also an opening of vast energy resources in the Caspian region in the 1990s due to the collapse of the Soviet Union and subsequent liberalization of

policies in newly independent states. These conditions created new opportunities for the U.S. — it promoted the establishment of new export routes to bypass Russia and Iran, such as the Baku-Tbilisi-Ceyhan pipeline. The intention was to diversify energy supplies, reduce Russian control over post-Soviet supplies and reduce Europe's dependence on Russia. The Caspian region appeared to be a promising alternative to Middle Eastern oil. By investing in infrastructure and building alliances with countries like Azerbaijan and Georgia, the U.S. sought to ensure greater energy security for itself and its allies. However, for Russia these actions were a challenge for the historically important geopolitical sphere of influence, reducing Russia's monopoly on Caspian oil exports, and forcing it to seek new markets and build alternative export routes (as the Nord Stream). The U.S. efforts to reduce European dependency on Russian gas sowed the seeds of future competition in the LNG sector. While the 1990s were a period of relative weakness for Russia, its power was reinforced in the early 2000s, particularly through the consolidation of Gazprom's control over key gas export routes, including asset swaps with EU energy companies and geo-economic strategies. After the 1990s, the United States reduced its overseas military activities outside of its bases in NATO countries, East Asia, and the Persian Gulf as there were no significant geopolitical opponents. However, in the 2000s, the U.S. military operations in the Middle East and Afghanistan increased, accompanied with new access to military infrastructure in Central Asian states, and new presence in Africa and the Arctic.

The early 2000s marked the beginning of a gradual shift in United States energy policy. While the 1990s had focused on regional conflicts and infrastructure development, the early 2000s saw a broader, more strategic engagement in the global energy markets. This period was also marked by rising concerns over U.S. energy dependency and the growing importance of natural gas. Advances in technology and the discovery of vast shale gas reserves in the United States set the stage for future

shale revolution. This shift reduced its Middle East oil dependence and positioned the U.S. to be a long-term worldwide natural gas market leader. The terrorist attacks of September 11, 2001, and 2003 Iraq intervention further underscored the vulnerabilities of relying on foreign energy supplies. This led to increased calls for energy independence and greater investment in domestic energy resources (Klare, 2004). Hurricane Katrina (2005) damaged a significant part of oil platforms in the Mexican Gulf. Oil prices increased.

Overall, unlike the intense and strategic engagement seen during the 1970s oil crisis or the aggressive push for dominance after the shale revolution, this period was characterized by selective and episodic interventions driven primarily by geopolitical interests rather than comprehensive energy strategies. U.S. involvement in the energy sector during these years was driven by regional conflicts, post-Cold War resource competition, and efforts to diversify energy supply routes to reduce dependency on politically volatile regions.

1.3 The U.S. Energy Policy Formation

To explain the influence of the U.S. globally in the sphere of energy, it is important to understand how the U.S. energy policy is formulated, implemented and controlled. It is formulated via a decentralized, multi-layered process between the legislative, executive, and judicial branches of government and significant independent agencies and private sector influence.

Speaking about the legislative branch, represented by Congress, it plays a central role in debating, drafting and passing laws, including those related to energy and environmental standards and foreign relations. Main U.S. energy laws are Energy Policy Act of 2005 (Pub. L. No. 109-58, 2005)[19] and the Energy Independence and Security Act of 2007 (Pub. L. No. 110-140, 2007)[20]. They establish targets for renewable energy, energy efficiency, and modernization of energy infrastructure. The Energy Policy Act of 2005 is a landmark expansion of U.S. energy policy with direct effects both on domestic production and the emerging role in global energy markets. The Act was signed into law on August 8, 2005, and authorized $14.5 billion in tax credits designed to boost domestic energy production across several industry sectors such as oil, natural gas, coal, nuclear energy, and renewables. In the oil and gas sector, it authorized subsidies for offshore drilling, mandated leasing federal lands, and accelerated environmental review of energy projects, thus accelerating fossil fuel development. It also promoted the construction of LNG terminals by granting the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission (FERC) exclusive authority to license LNG facilities (Sec. 311), a critical action which later enabled the U.S. LNG export boom after 2016. Additionally, the Act created a framework for promoting biofuels, requesting 7.5 billion gallons of renewable fuels to be blended into gasoline by 2012 (Renewable Fuel Standard, Sec. 1501). By promoting a diverse mix of energy sources

[19] U.S. Congress. (2005). Energy Policy Act of 2005, Public Law 109-58. https://www.congress.gov/109/plaws/publ58/PLAW-109publ58.pdf

[20] U.S. Congress. (2007). Energy Independence and Security Act of 2007, Public Law 110-140. https://www.congress.gov/bill/110th-congress/house-bill/6

and fostering infrastructure development, the Energy Policy Act of 2005 laid the basis for the U.S. shale revolution and the USA rise as a leading energy exporter. The Energy Independence and Security Act of 2007 aimed at reducing U.S. dependence on oil and promoting sustainability in energy consumption. Signed into law on December 19, 2007, it raised Corporate Average Fuel Economy (CAFE) standards significantly, mandating that new cars and light trucks achieve 35 miles per gallon (mpg) by 2020, up from the previous average of 27.5 mpg. It also raised the Renewable Fuel Standard (RFS), requiring the blending of 36 billion gallons of biofuels annually by 2022, up from 7.5 billion gallons previously mandated in the 2005 Energy Policy Act. The Act also promoted energy efficiency in buildings and appliances and provided funding for research into advanced battery technologies for electric vehicles. EISA reflected strategic reorientation to energy security via diversification and climate-oriented policies that shaped the framework of U.S. foreign energy interactions, particularly in strengthening clean energy innovation-based alliances and in underpinning the legitimacy of U.S. leadership within global climate negotiations. Latest 2022 Inflation Reduction Act (Pub. L. No. 117-169) is the most climate-focused bill ever enacted into law in American history. It is set to invest approximately $369 billion on clean energy development and emissions reduction programs over ten years. It includes across-the-board tax credits to encourage installation of renewable energy, including extended credits for solar, wind, battery storage, and clean hydrogen projects. The Act also provides significant incentives to purchase electric vehicles and to encourage the building of carbon capture and storage (CCS) technology. In addition to national policy, the IRA was aimed to strengthen American credibility at global climate negotiations.

As for the executive branch, which includes president and executive agencies, the president sets overall direction, particularly in foreign energy policy, through directives, orders and national strategies. For this research Obama's, Biden's and

Trump's actions are assessed, with influence of personality on foreign energy policy, which is strong in the USA as there is in fact a strong role of president and his direction and strategic view. It is evident in how easily Trump (in recent 2025 term) blocked over 70 climate and green energy initiatives of Biden's administration, for example, bans on new offshore drilling, exiting the Paris Climate Agreement, and halting substantial green energy funding. These actions removed federal climate targets of decarbonizing the electricity sector by 2035 and achieving 50% electric vehicle sales by 2030 (Williams, 2025). Barack Obama (2009-2017) focused on clean energy and climate change, through, for example the Clean Power Plan, while Donald Trump (2017-2021) emphasized energy independence and fossil fuel development, rolling back several environmental regulations. And Joe Biden (2021-2025) prioritized rejoining the Paris Agreement and passed the IRA to promote clean energy. In fact American energy policy reflected the vision of the state leader in each term.

Key agencies responsible for energy policy formulation and implementation are: the Department of Energy — nuclear energy, efficiency, Strategic Petroleum Reserve and technologies funding. Key figures were Steven Chu (2009-2013) who advocated for renewable energy and energy efficiency (as Obama), Rick Perry (2017-2019) who supported fossil fuel development and energy exports (same as Trump) and Jennifer Granholm (2021-2025) who focused on clean energy innovation and infrastructure (same as Biden). Next agency is the Department of State as it is responsible for energy diplomacy (for example, for the U.S.-EU Energy Council), it integrates energy policy in broader state's foreign policy through international negotiations and partnerships; Federal Energy Regulatory Commission is responsible for integrating renewable grids and for interstate transmission of electricity, natural gas, and oil; the Environmental Protection Agency states for environmental impacts of energy production — emission standards and assessment.

Federal courts enforce constitutional and administrative law, for example, ruling on environmental legislation (e.g., West Virginia v. EPA decision[21], 2022, limiting EPA regulatory powers). Whilst governments in states have independence concerning energy production and regulation within their territories (e.g., Texas oil extraction regulations, California renewable energy legislation). Utility and energy companies (like ExxonMobil, Chevron, NextEra Energy) and interest groups (like the American Petroleum Institute and the Solar Energy Industries Association) exert significant influence through lobbying, litigation, and public pressure. Therefore, U.S. domestic energy policy is not only a response to domestic economic and security needs but also a foundation for overall international influence. By promoting energy diversification, infrastructure investment, and export capability, the U.S. became a dominant energy supplier from being a top energy importer. These developments are vital for understanding the influence that has been left on global energy markets by its energy policy-making.

In sum, this chapter has demonstrated that energy has been not only an economic necessity but also a successful strategic tool of global geopolitics throughout history. From World War II to the 1973 oil crisis and the launch of the petrodollar system, the United States has increasingly incorporated energy security into foreign policy. Consequently, U.S. energy policy has been at the leading edge of conflict dynamics, alliances, and global market structures. Through the development of domestic shale production, legislative structures, and the extension of LNG exports, the U.S. has moved from dependency to dominance in global energy markets.

[21] West Virginia v. Environmental Protection Agency, 597 U.S. (2022). https://www.supremecourt.gov/opinions/21pdf/20-1530_n758.pdf

CHAPTER 2: THEORETICAL FOUNDATIONS OF U.S. ENERGY POLICY PROJECTION AND EU-RUSSIA ENERGY RELATIONS (2008-2024)

The transformation of world energy markets between 2008 and 2024 reformed the strategic environment in which the United States, Russia, and the European Union interacted with one another. The account for this transformation requires a theory capable of explaining not just modifications in material capacities, but shifting perceptions, institutions, and interdependencies that constituted energy relations. This chapter implements IR theories for the explanation: neoclassical realism, neoliberalism (complex interdependence), and constructivism (securitization theory) — to create a framework to examine U.S. global energy policy and EU-Russian gas relations. Neoclassical realism highlights how the United States employed its production of energy, especially since the shale revolution, to assert power abroad. Securitization theory and constructivism explain how energy was redefined as a security threat, particularly Russian gas supplies, and influenced both American and European debate. Neoliberalism and complex interdependence theory, however, highlight economic, institutional, and political ties that limited pure power competition and offered room for cooperation. By integrating these perspectives, the chapter argues that U.S. moves (though significant) represented only a part of a broader structural and political shift in Europe, with indigenous interests, regulation policies, and threat perceptions also critically determining the push away from Russia in terms of energy.

2.1 The Shale Revolution and U.S. Energy Independence as a Strategic Asset

Neoclassical realism provides a useful explanation of U.S. energy policy since 2008. Structural realist Kenneth Waltz (1959) discusses three ‘images’ of state analysis: first image — individual decision-makers, second — domestic politics and third — international. Neoclassical realism accounts for second and third images, combining rationale from domestic and foreign conditions. Gideon Rose (1998)

formulated the concept of neoclassical realism by arguing that while international structure limits states, foreign policies are filtered through domestic perceptions and capacities. Fareed Zakaria (1998) emphasized that the state's ability to convert material capabilities into global power is a function of its domestic strength, an idea performed in the U.S. capacity to convert its shale boom into global energy leverage. Randall Schweller (1998) further built on this by highlighting that states pursue not only security but also revisionist goals based on domestic politics — paralleling the way in which U.S. governments tied energy policy to broader strategies of international alliance rebalancing and limiting Russia's energy influence in Europe. Finally, Lobell, Ripsman, and Taliaferro (2009) specify leadership perceptions' role in translating systemic incentives into concrete foreign policies via elite consensus and state-society relations. Thus, neoclassical realism accounts for the way in which the U.S., in the face of options made possible through the shale revolution and elevated global energy prices generally, pursued the exercise of influence within EU's energy markets but did so on terms framed by domestic political agendas, institutional capabilities, and elite threat visions targeted at Russia.

The U.S. shale revolution reshaped the global energy landscape. Technological advancements in hydraulic fracturing and horizontal drilling turned the U.S. into the world's top oil and natural gas producer. Between 2007 and 2016, U.S. oil production increased by 75%, while natural gas production increased by 39%[22] (IPAA.org, n.d.). Hydraulic fracturing involves injecting high-pressure fluid into rock formations to release trapped hydrocarbons. It has been used since the 1940s but was significantly improved in the early 2000s. By 2016, hydraulically fractured horizontal wells accounted for 69% of all oil and natural gas wells drilled in the United States and 83%[23] of the total linear footage drilled (EIA, 2018). This new abundance of energy

[22] Independent Petroleum Association of America. (n.d.). Hydraulic fracturing: Unlocking America's energy resources. https://www.ipaa.org/fracking/

[23] U.S. Energy Information Administration. (2018, January 30). Hydraulically fractured horizontal wells account for most new oil and natural gas wells. https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=34732

allowed the U.S. to switch from a net importer to a major exporter of energy. In 2019, U.S. energy exports surpassed imports for the first time in over six decades[24]. In 2023 total energy exports reached a record high of approximately 29.50 quads, exceeding imports by about 7.80 quads[25]. Favourable market conditions also contributed to the success of the USA energy production. High oil prices in the mid-2000s incentivized investment in unconventional resources. Increase in prices was driven partially by rapidly developing Chinese industries. Between 2000 and 2007, China's oil demand grew by nearly 7% per year, putting pressure on supply (IEEJ, 2009). In July 2008, the nominal price of oil peaked at $145 per barrel (Hamilton, 2009). This increase made previously uneconomical oil extraction methods, such as unconventional oil development (e.g. hydraulic fracturing), financially viable. Moreover, unlike many countries where subsurface resources are state-owned, U.S. landowners have the right to profit from the minerals beneath their land (U.S. Department of the Interior, n.d.). This encouraged widespread exploration and development. The rise in domestic production had profound implications for U.S. oil imports. As local output grew, reliance on foreign oil diminished, leading to a significant reduction in imports. This shift enhanced energy security and altered trade balances. The U.S. also began exporting more petroleum products, capitalizing on its refining capacity and the quality of its crude oil. Political shifts also contributed to increased interest in energy production. The beginning of the Barack Obama administration in 2009 was marked by attention to energy security. He stated: "We have known for decades that our survival depends on finding new sources of energy. Yet we import more oil today than ever before"[26] (The White House, 2009). Secretary Vilsack later proclaimed: "Expanding our biofuels infrastructure provides a unique opportunity to spur rural

[24] USAFacts. (2023, May 14). Is the US energy independent? https://usafacts.org/articles/is-the-us-energy-independent/
[25] U.S. Energy Information Administration. (2024, July 15). U.S. energy facts explained: Imports and exports. https://www.eia.gov/energyexplained/us-energy-facts/imports-and-exports.php
[26] The White House. (2009, July 6). Transcript of President Obama's interview with Novaya Gazeta. https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/transcript-president-obamas-interview-with-novaya-gazeta

economic development while reducing our dependence on foreign oil - one of the great challenges of the 21st century"[27] (The White House, 2009).

Thus, from a neoclassical realism perspective, the American shale revolution can be regarded as a strategic response to pressures in the international system. Neoclassical realists argue that states respond to external opportunities and threats mediated by domestic variables like political leadership, technological innovation, and institutional arrangements (Ripsman, Taliaferro, & Lobell, 2009). The rapid increase in U.S. energy production since 2008 was more than an economic phenomenon but a deliberate rebalancing to enhance national power and reduce strategic vulnerability to oil supply shocks. Soaring oil prices, political instability in the historic source regions, and growing global competition — particularly from a rising China — created incentives for the U.S. to be more energy self-sufficient. Domestic technological innovation and political priority on energy security, driven by leadership under both George W. Bush and Barack Obama, allowed the United States to react to these systemic incentives. Dueck (2009) via Ripsman, Taliaferro, & Lobell, tested his model on three interventions conducted by the USA (Iraq, Vietnam and Korea) and showed that initiation was due to external threat, but execution and political framing was deeply conditioned by domestic politics, which is a classical situation. The presidents of the USA tend to initiate major interventions due to internal beliefs on national interests. This is also discussed in foreign policy analysis theories, which claim bounded rationality and absence of full knowledge to be reasons for certain foreign policy decisions (Simon, 1957). Domestic factors are very important for justification of foreign actions. Presidents in the U.S. have significant autonomy in foreign policy, especially regarding security, but they still have to navigate public opinion, party politics and media narratives, which also contribute to justification. Thus, apart from second and third 'images', individual level

[27] The White House. (2009, May 5). President Obama announces steps to support sustainable energy options. https://obamawhitehouse.archives.gov/the-press-office/president-obama-announces-steps-support-sustainable-energy-options

decision-making matters as well. But this will be discussed more in constructivist explanation. Domestic politics do not fully cause foreign actions but influence their form and how they are conducted. In the U.S. presidents consult their perceptions of national interest when thinking about aggressive foreign policies (Dueck, 2009). Thus, seeing national interest in defining the global energy market for U.S. interests and deteriorating EU-Russia relations led to increased perception of Russia as a threat and subsequent attempt to convince key Russian partners in that. The U.S. administrations used both hard and soft power in line with national interest conceptions but these were framed differently under Obama, Trump and Biden. Thus, the shale revolution can be described as a case where material capabilities (energy production) were increased to enforce the U.S.'s relative position in the international system.

2.2 Securitization of Russian Energy in the U.S. and the EU

Constructivist theory of IR is an important tool to analyze behavior, actions and motivations of the U.S., Russia and the EU to reveal the link of construction of identity, framing of threats and subsequent measures taken by states. Constructivism as a theory in IR was developed in the 1990s. It questions materialism and ascribed rationalism of actors in previous theories and focuses on the role of ideas, maintaining that international politics is shaped not only by material power but also by social structures, shared ideas, and intersubjective meanings. It considers states acting in international anarchy, similar to realism and liberalism, but this anarchy is not stable and objective, rather constructed by states themselves, reacting to contexts depending on their perception of reality. According to Guzzini (2000), main constructivist ideas are social construction of knowledge and of social reality. Alexander Wendt, one of the first constructivist scholars, famously claimed in his foundational work 'Anarchy is What States Make of It: The Social Construction of Power Politics' (1992) that all aspects of relations between states are products of human action that historically constructed identities and norms, including threats, national interest, balance of power and importance given to material structures and capabilities. Multiple meanings can be assigned to different ideas. Constructivism rejects objectivity of systemic pressures and justification of foreign policy actions through objective reality reasoning. Wendt (1987) discussed agent-structure debate, pointing to the fact that agent and structure are mutually constitutive — the international system influences states in the same manner that states are able to influence the system. States are also influenced by each other, and are able to regulate and leverage this influence.

In Social Theory of International Politics, Wendt (1999) observed three cultures of anarchy. Different representations of Self and Other influence these cultures. Identity and national interest are linked. If Russia perceives itself as a large energy exporter and important partner of the European Union — its interest is to maintain it. It is similar to the 'otherness' applied by Western culture to Eastern, especially given

ideological rivalry between Russian traditional values and U.S-promoted progressivism. Russia-EU relations in the 1990s were based on friendship and mutual desire for cooperation — Kantian culture, where partnership and diplomacy are prioritised; then, between 2006 and 2014, Lockean culture came — characterized by suspicion and competition, subsequently leading to advent of Hobbesian culture which prevails nowadays — with no trust and desire to rely on each other. In U.S.-Russia relations, truly Kantian friendship, was not clearly present. It would be more correct to say that these relations began from Lockean rivalry leading to Hobbesian in the 2000s which preserves nowadays in an explicit form by both parts. These 'cultures' are not determined by structure of reality, as in Waltz's neorealism, rather, by historically contingent social practices and shared understandings that shape how states behave nowadays.

Values are very important for construction of national interest. Constructivism supposes that states with radically different identities behave as realists — aiming to gain power and prevent changing balance while maintaining survival through self-help strategies, while those with similar identities behave as liberals — aiming to preserve peace by cooperation, negotiation and economic integration. This confirms that the feeling of otherness contributes to subjective perception of states and threats from it — contributing to rivalry between Russia and the USA, where the European Union appeared to be an involved actor, which also has domestic interests, but is not fully independent in the formulation of a greater agenda towards Russia. For constructivists threats are not given, but issues are framed as security concerns through discourse and institutional practices. Russia-EU economic relations are represented not purely by rational utility maximising actions, but are deeply political, and from 2014 till 2022 were strongly constructed as a security threat by the EU itself, and by external actors with their national interests, such as the USA.

Securitisation theory of the Copenhagen school was developed by a group of scholars. Foundational work of Buzan, Wæver & de Wilde (1998) highlights how

threats are becoming objectivized and given extreme importance as security matters. In contrast to traditional security studies, in the securitization framework it could be said that 'threats are what states make of them' — as everything can become a vital threat if correctly framed. Securitization shows how the language of security is used to emphasize certain issues as more important and dangerous than others. These securitising moves — arguments promoted through language, diffusion of the idea of being threatened by, for example, dependence on Russian gas — if accepted by decision-making elites, provoke securitising extraordinary measures that are justified as pursuit of national interest and defence of the state and people. This helps the state to mobilise public support. The USA by promoting the idea of Russian threat, supported and reinforced by the EU, contributed to break of the partnership and increase of rivalry.

Securitization is an important part of modern wars and other questionable decisions that are generally not supported by the public — with globalization of information it became crucial to justify actions against the masses (especially in democracies — as the USA and EU states). Thus, the influence of the media and articulated discourse plays a role. By shaping perceptions of Russian gas as coercive and politically dangerous (securitizing moves), the U.S. contributed to EU's securitization of energy dependency (acceptance of the move) and to delegitimization of Russia as a reliable supplier — with radical actions and rejection of cooperation (extraordinary measures). These measures do not have to be rational (as classical IR theories assume), but can be results of miscalculations and subjectivity. Internal concerns over Russian gas dangers were present in the EU since the 2006 crisis, reinforced in 2009 — just the time of the shale revolution, but significant actions began after 2014, a very convenient moment for the USA to contribute to the discourse that blames Russia and to rapidly increase LNG exports. At the same time, the EU's response was shaped not only by threat narratives but also by market competition and asymmetric interdependencies.

2.3 EU-Russia Energy Relations Before 2022

Neoliberal institutionalism and complex interdependence theories are useful to explain EU-Russia relations before 2022. These theories, developed by Robert Keohane and Joseph Nye, emphasize that states cooperate not because they are nice but because institutions, regimes, and economic interdependence create mutual benefit, predictability, and constraint of unilateral action (Keohane & Nye, 1977; Keohane, 1984). There are multiple channels and actors involved and foreign policy of state is influenced by: goals of actors (EU institutions, state interests, corporations, Russian energy companies and authorities etc.); instruments of state policy — ability to manipulate interdependence to promote national agendas — what Russia did using energy as a "tool of intimidation and blackmail"[28] (words of Dick Cheney, the Vice President of the USA) (Bigg, 2006) — this was the case due to asymmetric interdependence in which Russia had opportunity to be better off and prioritise political gains over economic; and agenda formation — multiplicity of actors gives opportunity to all of them promote their agenda and justify actions through it. Neoliberal scholars claim that high levels of interconnectedness, especially economic, mitigate conditions of anarchy and prevent conflicts (Nye and Keohane, 2012). But this cannot fully explain events in EU-Russia relations after 2022, when actors ceased to value economic priorities over ideological and strategic ones. Events after the 2022 Ukraine crisis may seem irrational from liberal point of view: these actions prevented friendly mutually beneficial development of geographically close economies of Russia, Ukraine and European states for years. Further actions and relations are better explained by constructivist securitization of energy dependence, which goes back to 2000s crises and suspicions supported by the USA. Overall, in conditions of interdependence states value absolute gains and prioritise cooperation and friendship. That once was the case of Russia and the EU.

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[28] Bigg, C. (2006, May 10). Russia: Putin speech puts domestic concerns before foreign policy. RadioFreeEurope/RadioLiberty. https://www.rferl.org/a/1068299.html

Russia for many years defined the European Union as a valuable partner and saw broad perspectives in the development of cooperation and shared projects. Establishment of political partnership, free access to the EU market and financial assistance were priority interests in relations with the EU in the 1990s. This is evident in the adoption of the EU-Russia partnership and cooperation agreement (1994)[29] and in the overall Kozyrev doctrine that defined Russia as a part of Western world. European identity was desirable and efforts of economic integration, cultural exchange and political relations were promoted. This desire was mutual and was reciprocally reinforced since the 1990s. Cooperation began in Soviet times, when there was no Russian Federation, nor the European Union, but were their predecessors in the face of the USSR and the European Communities. Institutionalized and accepted rules and market benefits were the basis for this partnership. Historically, the EU and Russia have maintained significant energy ties, with Russia being one of the EU's largest suppliers of natural gas and oil.

In the majority of the post-Cold War period, energy relations between Russia and the EU were structured by the logic of Russia being a reliable supplier and European market being lucrative for the Russian budget, resembling the logic of neoliberal institutionalism. This relationship has been mutually beneficial, but led to mutual dependence. The dependency rate was equal to 56% in 2000[30], and to 58% in 2018, with Russia still standing on the first place as the import state of crude oil, natural gas and fossil fuels (Eurostat, 2020). However, these ties have also produced geopolitical tension, particularly as the EU seeks to balance its energy security with political, environmental and strategic considerations. Despite deep economic interdependence, internal disagreements in the EU and asymmetrical dependence produced concerns and contradictions over the relationship with Russia.

While the European Union is commonly regarded as acting as a single actor in

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[29] Partnership and Cooperation Agreement (1994, June 6). Retrieved from: https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/ALL/?uri=CELEX:21997A1128(01)

[30] Eurostat (2020). Shedding light on energy in the EU. Retrieved from: https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/cache/infographs/energy_2020/images/pdf/pdf-energy-eurostat-2020.pdf

the field of energy policy, member states did not have a unique view on dependence on Russian gas. Constructivism can explain this divergence, as identity of state and its perceptions of external environment are influenced by historical ties and perceptions of past experience. For instance, Germany's cooperative energy policy was shaped by its strong industrial ties to Russia and its Ostpolitik heritage, which saw long-term agreements and projects like Nord Stream as stabilizers rather than threats. In contrast, Poland and the Baltic States, based on historical experience of Soviet hegemony, viewed Russian energy as a tool of coercion and actively promoted diversification and EU-level regulation. This divergence was underpinned by deeper national interests: while Western member states appreciated economic efficiency and energy supply security, Eastern members appreciated sovereignty and threat mitigation. The European Commission increasingly joined the securitization camp, portraying energy dependence as a strategic weakness. Meanwhile, nations like Italy and Hungary continued to push for closer ties with Russian producers, demonstrating that EU-level responses to Russia's energy policy were shaped by varied domestic political calculations and elite threat perception. This internal fragmentation slowed down cohesive energy policy and made the EU's diversification away from Russian gas a controversial and slow process, only accelerated by external shocks like the 2014 and 2022 Ukrainian crises.

Since 2014, the geopolitical landscape has been dramatically altered by Russia's reunification with Crimea and the subsequent conflict in Eastern Ukraine, which in 2022 evolved into open military confrontation with Russia declaring a beginning of a Special Military Operation. Ukraine has always been a 'geopolitical pivot' (Brzezinski, 1997) and a transit country for Russian supplies to the EU. With growing instability in Ukraine, 2004 Orange revolution, 2006 and 2009 gas crises, European confidence in reliable supplies through Ukraine slowly downgraded. These developments have led to a reassessment of energy dependencies within the EU, with growing concerns over Russia's willingness to use energy as a geopolitical tool. The

United States, recognizing these vulnerabilities, has actively sought to influence EU energy policies, promoting diversification of energy sources and reducing reliance on Russian energy. This included diplomatic efforts, economic sanctions, and support for alternative energy projects, such as LNG exports from the U.S. and the development of the Southern Gas Corridor. For example, in 2022 the EU-U.S. Task Force on Energy Security was established with a specific primary aim outlined: "to reduce the EU's reliance on Russian energy"[31] — so the U.S. aims to directly help the EU to lower cooperation with Russia. After 2014 EU neoliberal institutions shifted from facilitating interdependence with Russia to crafting resilience strategies. This comprised support for construction of LNG terminals in Poland, Lithuania, and Croatia, for interconnector pipelines (such as the Balticconnector and BRUA), and serious investment in renewables infrastructure through initiatives like the Recovery and Resilience Facility[32]. These moves represent a functional deployment of institutional capacity not towards cooperation, but towards market reorientation. The EU Energy Union plan (2015)[33] and REPowerEU plan (2022)[34] also had a well-defined normative and strategic aim in reshaping the EU's energy policy. These plans redefined energy dependence as a vulnerability that must be actively addressed. Security of supply, diversification, and internal market integration were foregrounded in the Energy Union, which was created as a response to the 2014 Crimean crisis. REPowerEU, created in response to the 2022 instability in Ukraine, had the particular aim of ending EU dependence on Russian fossil fuels, with LNG imports, renewables, and upgrading infrastructure being prioritized. It is stated there that this is: "a plan to rapidly reduce dependence on Russian fossil fuels and fast forward the green

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[31] U.S. Embassy & Consulates in Italy. (2023, April 3). Joint statement on U.S.-EU Task Force on Energy Security. https://it.usembassy.gov/joint-statement-on-u-s-eu-task-force-on-energy-security/

[32] European Commission. (2024, October 4). The Recovery and Resilience Facility (RRF). https://commission.europa.eu/business-economy-euro/economic-recovery/recovery-and-resilience-facility_en

[33] European Parliament. (2015, March 5). Energy Union: New impetus for coordination and integration of energy policies in the EU (Briefing No. 551310). https://www.europarl.europa.eu/RegData/etudes/BRIE/2015/551310/EPRS_BRI(2015)551310_EN.pdf

[34] European Commission (2022). REPowerEU Plan. COM(2022) 230 final. https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/?uri=COM:2022:230:FIN&qid=1653033742483

transition"[35]. Together, these policies institutionalized the securitization of Russian energy and reset the strategic direction of the EU.

In general, the initial basis of EU-Russia energy ties was interdependence, which reflected reciprocal economic gain and formalized engagement under shared regulations. However, internal contradictions in EU states' threat perceptions, national interests, elite narratives, and external geopolitical crises, replaced the basis of friendship and cooperation on suspicion and hostility. As a result, the EU increasingly reframed energy relations with Russia as an area of strategic burden and put political threat perceptions as more important ones. Neoliberal institutional tools, initially devised to foster integration and efficiency, were re-routed to enhance diversification.

A multi-theory framework is useful to explain the development of U.S. energy policy and EU-Russia energy relations from 2008 to 2024. Neoclassical realism explains how America used its shale revolution to gain more strategic autonomy as well as projecting power abroad, particularly in Europe. Constructivist securitization theory explains how discourse in both the EU and the USA built Russian energy as an existential threat, thus warranting extraordinary measures. Neoliberal institutionalism sheds light on the economic interdependence which earlier bound Russia and the EU together but then broke apart due to asymmetric dependencies. Acting in tandem, the U.S. was an actor that not only played a part in material alterations (such as LNG exports) but also helped to shape the ideational sphere which drove the EU to conceptualize energy from an economic to a security issue. This complex dynamic of material power, discourse, and institutional logic gave rise to a gradual but deep shift in the energy architecture and strategic position of Europe.

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[35] European Commission. (2022, May 18). REPowerEU: A plan to rapidly reduce dependence on Russian fossil fuels and fast forward the green transition. https://enlargement.ec.europa.eu/news/repowereu-plan-rapidly-reduce-dependence-russian-fossil-fuels-and-fast-forward-green-transition-2022-05-18_en

CHAPTER 3: ANALYSIS OF THE U.S. ENERGY POLICY AND ITS GLOBAL IMPACT (2008-2024)

The emergence of the United States as a top energy producer since 2008 transformed the global energy map. The shale revolution made it possible for succeeding U.S. administrations to pursue an ambitious energy policy that included using energy as a strategic tool for foreign policy, reshaping global energy patterns, gaining access to foreign markets for U.S. liquefied natural gas, and achieving energy independence. This chapter examines the evolution of U.S. global energy policy between 2008 and 2024 in four broad phases: 2008-2013 (from the shale revolution to Crimean crisis), 2014-2016 (from Crimean crisis to Trump administration), 2017-2021 (Trump administration and Biden administration until 2022 Russia-Ukraine conflict), and 2022-2024 (from Russia-Ukraine conflict to recent times), examining the ways in which Washington used economic, normative, diplomatic, and discursive tools to enhance its position in the world energy system. Although specific focus is given to the implications for Russia and EU-Russia relations, the analysis places these events in the larger context of U.S. efforts to open up energy market access, counter competitors, and advance American energy as an economic resource and a geopolitical tool.

3.1 2008-2013: Shale Revolution and Multilateral Engagement

Between 2008 and 2014, the United States began its strategic re-entry into global energy markets, driven primarily by the shale revolution. Advances in technology led to growth in oil and gas production and paved the way for future energy exports. According to the IEA (2019), the shale revolution allowed the U.S. to significantly transform energy markets both at home and abroad, shifting from energy scarcity to abundance, boosting global energy security and thus becoming a global leader in energy technologies and altering trade flows particularly via crude oil and

LNG exports. Dr Fatih Birol, the IEA's Executive Director, supported[36] U.S. efforts to simplify regulatory approval process for LNG exports as a benefit for importer states' diversification of supplies. Overall, the U.S. was very successful in benefiting from its energy: it became the world's largest producer of crude oil in 2018, surpassing Saudi Arabia, the largest exporter of liquefied natural gas in 2022, surpassing Australia and Qatar[37] and a net total energy exporter in 2019 (exported more energy than imported) for the first time since the 1950s[38]. Between 2008 and 2024 U.S. leadership was market-driven, with increased interest in times of better ability to promote national interest and benefit from new markets. It involved institutional infrastructure, like the deregulation of export controls, authorization for the first LNG terminals, and regulatory reforms by the DOE and FERC. The U.S. framed its energy transition in the context of energy independence and technological superiority, providing itself a stable influential role on the world stage in the years ahead.

In **2008**, U.S. foreign policy reflected a period of cooperation, pragmatic engagement, and strategic energy diplomacy. There were 22 official U.S. press releases related to Russia that year. In general, relations were peaceful and aimed at mutual respect and desire to preserve neutrality. High-level diplomatic engagement included the visit of Under Secretary Reuben Jeffery III to Moscow for economic and energy talks[39], and the launch of the U.S.-Russia Economic Dialogue under the

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[36] International Energy Agency. (2019, September 13). The US shale revolution has reshaped the energy landscape at home and abroad, according to latest IEA policy review. https://www.iea.org/news/the-us-shale-revolution-has-reshaped-the-energy-landscape-at-home-and-abroad-according-to-latest-iea-policy-review

[37] U.S. Energy Information Administration. (2023). *Oil and petroleum products explained: Where our oil comes from*. https://www.eia.gov/energyexplained/oil-and-petroleum-products/where-our-oil-comes-from.php#:~:text=The%20United%20States%20became%20the,States%20and%20in%20other%20countries

[38] U.S. Energy Information Administration. (2024). *U.S. energy facts explained: Imports and exports*. https://www.eia.gov/energyexplained/us-energy-facts/imports-and-exports.php

[39] U.S. Department of State. (2008, January 28). Under Secretary for Economic, Energy and Agricultural Affairs Reuben Jeffery III travels to Russia (Media Note No. 2008/061). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/jan/99778.htm

broader Strategic Framework Declaration[40], aimed at deepening institutionalized economic cooperation.

Civil nuclear energy cooperation was a central pillar of U.S. engagement. Several major agreements were signed: with Bahrain[41], the UAE[42], India[43], and Russia[44]. The U.S.-Russia 123 Agreement and Joint Declaration on Nuclear Energy and Nonproliferation reemphasized shared vision for expansion of civilian nuclear power and international nonproliferation leadership, particularly among the developing nations[45]. Beyond nuclear policy, the U.S. strengthened its role in renewable and alternative energy markets. It showcased climate leadership at the Washington International Renewable Energy Conference[46] and promoted sustainable development through biofuels cooperation with Brazil[47] and third countries in Africa, Latin America[48], and the Caribbean. It also supported energy efficiency in China through the Asia-Pacific Partnership[49].

However, the tone of U.S. discourse toward Russia began to shift after the August 2008 Russia-Georgia war. Washington's response portrayed Russia as a

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[40]U.S. Department of State. (2008, April 25). Inaugural session of the U.S.-Russia Economic Dialogue (Media Note No. 2008/321). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/apr/104068.htm

[41] U.S. Department of State. (2008, March 24). U.S.-Bahraini memorandum of understanding on nuclear energy cooperation (Media Note No. 2008/218). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/mar/102567.htm

[42] U.S. Department of State. (2008, April 21). U.S.-United Arab Emirates memorandum of understanding on nuclear energy cooperation (Media Note No. 2008/305). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/apr/103859.htm

[43] U.S. Department of State. (2008, October 2). Congressional approval of the U.S.-India agreement for cooperation concerning peaceful uses of nuclear energy (123 Agreement) (Statement by Secretary Condoleezza Rice, No. 2008/822). https://2001-2009.state.gov/secretary/rm/2008/10/110554.htm

[44] U.S. Department of State. (2008, May 6). U.S.-Russia agreement for peaceful nuclear cooperation (123 Agreement) (Press Statement No. 2008/356). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/may/104400.htm

[45] U.S. Department of State. (2008, July 3). Joint U.S.-Russian statement: One year of progress following the joint declaration on nuclear energy and nonproliferation (Media Note No. 2008/543). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/07/106502.htm

[46] U.S. Department of State. (2008, February 25). Washington International Renewable Energy Conference: March 4-6, 2008 (Fact Sheet No. 2008/139). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/feb/101276.htm

[47] U.S. Department of State. (2008, November 20). Joint statement by the United States and Brazil announcing the expansion of cooperation on biofuels to advance energy security and promote sustainable development. (Media Note No. 2008/978) https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/nov/112120.htm

[48] U.S. Department of State. (2008, October 1). United States and Uruguay sign memorandum of understanding to advance cooperation on renewable energy and energy efficiency (Media Note No. 2008/820). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/oct/110546.htm

[49] U.S. Department of State. (2008, December 2). Asia-Pacific Partnership on Clean Development and Climate: Promoting building energy efficiency in China (Notice to the Press No. 2008/1004). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/dec/112573.htm

destabilizing actor in the post-Soviet space, calling for international monitors[50] and emphasizing Georgia's territorial integrity[51] — laying early groundwork for the later securitization of Russian behavior and energy policy. Overall, U.S. global energy policy in 2008 was defined by cooperative engagement, institution-building in nuclear governance, market-based expansion into alternative fuels, and early signs of geopolitical reorientation in response to Russian actions.

In **2009** there were a total 11 press releases that directly or indirectly referenced Russia within the context of energy diplomacy and overall 25 releases related to energy. They referred to high-level engagements, multilateral summits, bilateral cooperation, strategic communication on global energy security and climate diplomacy. The United States sought to reassert global leadership not only through military alliances or market dominance, but by shaping norms and institutional frameworks around energy security and climate governance. The Obama administration supported constructive dialogue with Russia through the U.S.-Russia Bilateral Presidential Commission, where energy was one of the central areas of mutual interest, framed as requiring transparency and market liberalization. This Commission included Energy and Environment and Nuclear Energy and Nuclear Security working groups (The White House, 2009). In general, the beginning of the Obama presidency coincided with hopes for liberal turn of Russia under Medvedev's. Russia suffered from the 2008 economic crisis and needed money for modernization of the economy, so cooperation with the West was a priority, while non-Western partners were still very important for economic and image development on the international arena. NATO enlargement was freezed for a time and in general there was less criticism of Russia under the 'reset'. A North Distribution Network was established that allowed the USA to supply NATO in Afghanistan through Russia.

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[50] U.S. Department of State. (2008, September 19). Russia/Georgia: Deploying EU and OSCE international mechanisms (Press Statement No. 2008/752, Sean McCormack). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/sept/110028.htm

[51] U.S. Department of State. (2008, August 8). Russian actions in Georgia (Press Statement No. 2008/627, Robert Wood, Acting Deputy Spokesman). https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2008/aug/108097.htm

The NATO-Russia council began to function again after its suspension in 2008 due to Russian actions in Georgia. Thus, in general, there were mutual hopes on increasing trust, transparency and economic cooperation. Bilateral energy diplomacy with Russia — energy cooperation in the U.S.-Russia 'reset', discursive shift marked by Secretary Clinton's repeated emphasis[52] on mutual respect, shared responsibility, pragmatic engagement and joint technological collaboration in areas like energy efficiency and Arctic policy signaled a move from containment to cooperative security — especially tempered by concerns over Iran, Georgia, and NATO expansion. After the 2009 Ukraine-Russia gas crisis the USA supported diversification of European gas supplies: "... need for transparent, market-oriented arrangements for the sale and shipment of natural gas and the importance of diversifying energy supplies. The United States stands ready to support European Union efforts to enhance its energy security." — said Robert Wood[53], acting State Department spokesman. Despite general attempts to build positive relations, U.S. actions began to support European desire to avoid Russian supplies. Important element was positioning climate change as a core issue.

The U.S. promoted itself as a leader in the climate change fight. In April 2009 it launched the Major Economies Forum on Energy and Climate, framing climate cooperation as urgent and central to global stability, formulating securitization of climate change as a shared global security concern, allowing the U.S. to convene major economies as co-stakeholders in the transition to low-carbon development (U.S. Department of State, 2009). In the Asia-Pacific, the Obama administration promoted a shared leadership model, particularly in the U.S.-China energy diplomacy. The July 2009 Memorandum of Understanding on Enhancing Cooperation on Climate Change,

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[52] U.S. Department of State. (2009, May 7). Remarks with Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov after their meeting (Press Availability No. 2009/431, Hillary Rodham Clinton, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/20092013clinton/rm/2009a/05/123073.htm

[53] U.S. Department of State. (2009, January 19). Ukraine/Russia: Agreement to restore gas flows to Europe (Press Statement No. 2009/070, Robert Wood, Acting Spokesman). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2009/01/115295.htm

Energy and the Environment at the U.S.China Strategic and Economic Dialogue[54] formalized dialogues between American and Chinese ministries, positioning clean energy as both a diplomatic bridge and a market frontier. This agreement emphasized technology transfer, joint research, and low-carbon growth, redefining U.S.-China rivalry into potential synergy[55]. Clinton's remarks[56] at the Taiyang Gong power plant framed this as a 'comprehensive' and 'collaborative' response to global risk, with both nations responsible for leading a sustainable energy transition. The administration also strategically used discourse around 'energy security' to deepen ties in regions vulnerable to political instability.

The launch of the Bilateral Energy Security Working Group with Ukraine[57] (stressing the need to address Ukrainian energy security issues and provide technical assistance) and the Pakistan Signature Energy Program[58] (with $125 million help) exemplified energy diplomacy as soft power — addressing development challenges while advancing U.S. geopolitical interests. By framing energy aid in terms of infrastructure modernization, governance reform, and private sector engagement, the U.S. projected itself as a stabilizing force in Eurasia and South Asia.

Discourse around nuclear energy further reveals how the U.S. leveraged legal and normative frameworks to counter proliferation threats. The 2009 U.S.-UAE "123 Agreement"[59] was celebrated as a model of peaceful nuclear development —

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[54]U.S. Department of State. (2009, June 12). Remarks on the U.S. delegation's June 7–10 trip to China to discuss climate and energy issues (Remarks No. 2009/588, Todd Stern, Special Envoy for Climate Change). https://2009-2017.state.gov/e/oes/rls/remarks/2009/124705.htm

[55] U.S. Department of State. (2009, July 28). Memorandum of understanding on enhancing cooperation on climate change, energy and the environment at the U.S.-China Strategic and Economic Dialogue (Fact Sheet No. 2009/790). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2009/july/126597.htm

[56] U.S. Department of State. (2009, February 21). Dialogue on U.S.-China partnership on clean energy (Remarks No. 2009/T1-24, Hillary Rodham Clinton, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/20092013clinton/rm/2009a/02/119433.htm

[57] U.S. Department of State. (2009, October 28). United States and Ukraine announce bilateral energy security working group (Media Note No. 2009/1076). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2009/oct/131024.htm

[58] U.S. Department of State. (2009, October 28). The United States announces the Pakistan Signature Energy Program (Media Note No. 2009/T14-4). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2009/oct/130995.htm

[59] U.S. Department of State. (2009, May 21). Agreement for cooperation between the Government of the United States and Government of the United Arab Emirates concerning peaceful uses of nuclear energy (Fact Sheet No. 2009/491). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2009/05/123748.htm

explicitly contrasted with Iran's program. This reinforced the U.S.-led non-proliferation norm that rewarded transparency and disincentivized enrichment and reprocessing, while offering access to civilian nuclear technology under strict conditions. Through this sophisticated discursive strategy, the Obama administration advocated energy and climate goals and redefined international energy politics terminology. The U.S. became a global norm entrepreneur, bridging the gap between developed and developing countries, security and sustainability, and rivalry and cooperation. By placing energy within the diplomacy vocabulary — clean, peaceful, verifiable, shared — the U.S. set the cognitive and institutional structure of international energy management in 2009.

In **2010** there were 26 press releases regarding energy governance and cooperation. The Energy and Climate Partnership of the Americas (ECPA) was a cornerstone of U.S. energy diplomacy in Latin America. U.S. officials promoted a governance framework built on five pillars: efficiency, renewables, fossil fuel transition, infrastructure, and energy access. These efforts were reinforced at the World Urban Forum[60] in March, where Brazil's sustainable urbanization initiative was praised and supported through the U.S.-backed academic and policy networks. At the ECPA Ministerial[61] in April, Secretary Clinton launched new initiatives including biomass energy research, Caribbean interconnection dialogues, and Peace Corps deployments for grassroots clean energy access. This broadened ECPA's reach beyond mitigation into adaptation and urban development. An accompanying joint op-ed[62] by Secretaries Hillary Clinton and Steven Chu framed clean energy cooperation as a strategic engine for hemispheric prosperity. On the global stage, the U.S. advanced dual-track climate diplomacy — supporting the UNFCCC while shaping

[60] U.S. Department of State. (2010, March 25). Energy and Climate Partnership of the Americas discussed at the World Urban Forum: Advancing sustainable urbanization (Media Note No. 2010/362). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/03/139079.htm

[61] U.S. Department of State. (2010, April 15). Secretary Clinton announces new initiatives under the Energy and Climate Partnership of the Americas (Fact Sheet No. 2010/455). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/04/140288.htm

[62] U.S. Department of State. (2010, April 16). Secretaries Clinton and Chu praise energy cooperation across the Americas in joint op-ed (Media Note No. 2010/465). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/04/140345.htm

complementary venues like the Major Economies Forum. In April, leaders affirmed the Copenhagen Accord and endorsed technology-focused cooperation in preparation for COP16[63]. Meanwhile, the launch of the Global Shale Gas Initiative (GSGI)[64] in August highlighted U.S. intent to export regulatory expertise and drive discourse on shale gas as a lower-carbon transitional fuel. Technical diplomacy was further institutionalized through the U.S.-China partnerships like the Ten-Year Framework on Environment and Energy[65], illustrating bilateral confidence-building through clean tech collaboration. The Deepwater Horizon spill in the Gulf of Mexico was mitigated by assistance from 17 nations and multiple international bodies, the U.S. carefully managed foreign aid while maintaining domestic operational control[66]. In Nigeria, the U.S. emphasized[67] regulatory reform, transparency, and private sector-led investment in both hydrocarbons and renewables. Similarly, the Signature Energy Program in Pakistan[68], expanded in July, tied hydroelectric and smart grid infrastructure to development goals and strategic regional stabilization.

The U.S.-Russia 'reset' remained a key channel for integrating energy into broader security agendas. Clinton's March visit to Moscow reaffirmed cooperation on energy efficiency, civil nuclear policy, and Afghanistan logistics[69]. This was deepened by the Plutonium Disposition Protocol[70] signed in April, reinforcing arms control

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[63] U.S. Department of State. (2010, April 19). Chair's summary of the sixth meeting of the Leaders' Representatives of the Major Economies Forum on Energy and Climate (Media Note No. 2010/479). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/04/140479.htm

[64] U.S. Department of State. (2010, August 20). Global Shale Gas Initiative (Notice to the Press No. 2010/1143). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/08/146161.htm

[65] U.S. Department of State. (2010, May 13). U.S.-China Ten-Year Framework for Cooperation on Energy and Environment (Media Note No. 2010/618). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/05/141822.htm

[66] U.S. Department of State. (2010, June 14). Deepwater Horizon oil spill: International offers of assistance (Media Note No. 2010/794). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/06/143127.htm

[67] U.S. Department of State. (2010, June 11). U.S.-Nigeria Energy and Investment Working Group meeting and grant signing (Media Note No. 2010/782). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/06/143018.htm

[68] U.S. Department of State. (2010, July 19). The United States announces Phase II of the Signature Energy Program for Pakistan (Fact Sheet No. 2010/969). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/07/144820.htm

[69] U.S. Department of State. (2010, March 18). Remarks with Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov (Press Availability No. 2010/T25-1, Hillary Rodham Clinton, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/20092013clinton/rm/2010/03/138531.htm

[70] U.S. Department of State. (2010, April 12). Secretary Clinton to sign Plutonium Disposition Protocol with Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov on Tuesday, April 13 (Notice to the Press No. 2010/434). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/04/140061.htm

through the lens of fissile material management. Further, NATO-Russia Council talks[71] in September revealed European security concerns, underlining that Russia is seen as a partner and not an adversary in maintaining security in Europe. In the U.S.-EU Energy Council[72] in November, energy diplomacy centered on the Southern Corridor, Ukrainian market reform, and shared research on smart grids, CCS, and rare earths. The Council stressed transatlantic regulatory convergence, especially in offshore drilling and unconventional gas development, showing institutional maturity in balancing market innovation with environmental oversight.

A defining element of 2010 policy was the escalation of energy-linked pressure on Iran. Through diplomatic outreach and legal risk signaling, the U.S. convinced[73] major firms like Shell, Total, LUKOIL, and Trafigura to withdraw from Iran's energy sector. These actions demonstrated how energy diplomacy could be used to isolate adversaries, enforce non-proliferation norms, and align market behavior with security objectives. Meanwhile, the U.S.-Canada Energy Consultative Mechanism[74] reaffirmed North America's integrated approach to energy governance, focusing on offshore regulation, CCS, and renewables. In 2010, U.S. foreign energy policy was characterized by institutionalization, innovation, and integration. Whether deepening ties with allies, responding to crises, isolating adversaries, or steering global norms, the Obama administration embedded energy into its broader strategy of multilateral leadership and economic diplomacy. From shale diplomacy and clean energy forums to nuclear security and market exits from Iran, energy became a strategic multiplier — blending climate imperatives with geopolitical calculus and statecraft.

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[71] U.S. Department of State. (2010, September 22). Briefing on Transatlantic Meetings and NATO-Russia Council meeting (Remarks No. 2010/1327, Philip H. Gordon, Assistant Secretary, Bureau of European and Eurasian Affairs). https://2009-2017.state.gov/p/eur/rls/rm/2010/147600.htm

[72] U.S. Department of State. (2010, November 19). Joint statement following the U.S.-EU Energy Council Ministerial, Lisbon (Media Note No. 2010/1682). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/11/151185.htm

[73] U.S. Department of State. (2010, September 30). Companies reducing energy-related business with Iran (Fact Sheet No. 2010/1373). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/09/148458.htm

[74] U.S. Department of State. (2010, December 6). U.S.-Canada Energy Consultative Mechanism meets (Media Note No. 2010/1760). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2010/12/152442.htm

In **2011**, American foreign energy policy was marked by a shift toward making energy diplomacy a pillar of national security, leadership on climate change, and geopolitics. There were 27 press releases on energy and Russia. With rhetoric emphasizing transparency, innovation, and rule-of-law-driven governance, the United States positioned itself as a normative leader in creating international energy markets — often implicitly contrasted to Russia's state-directed and fossil-fuel-ordered model. A defining innovation was the establishment of the Bureau of Energy Resources, launched to institutionalize energy as a core component of U.S. diplomacy. Ambassador Carlos Pascual[75] established its mandate on three pillars: the handling of energy geopolitics, the promotion of clean technology transitions, and the expansion of global energy access. Notably, Pascual's references to Russia were depoliticized — framings of as a 'key producer' whose market stability cooperation was necessary — repeating a technocratic, market-oriented language aimed at diffusing geopolitical strife while reaffirming control of global gas flows. US involvement in multilateral venues such as the International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA) and the U.S.-EU Energy Council also supported this normative agenda. At IRENA, the U.S. aligned with decarbonization principles that were not in Russia's hydrocarbon export interests. At the Energy Council the U.S., while recognizing Russia as an 'indispensable part of Europe's and the world's energy solutions,'[76] simultaneously appeals to Moscow to adopt open reforms and be a supporter of market openness. This dual position — recognizing Russia's energy importance while appealing to it to conform to Western standards — reflects the U.S. role in mediating the EU's dependence on Russian hydrocarbons. Moreover, U.S. support for projects like the Southern Corridor, Ukrainian integration into European energy networks, and investment promotion cooperation subtly shifts EU energy policy towards Russian supply alternatives (U.S. Department of State, 2011). Discursively, America

[75] U.S. Department of State. (2011, November 16). Briefing on the new Bureau of Energy Resources within the Department of State (Remarks by Ambassador Carlos Pascual). https://2009-2017.state.gov/e/enr/rls/177281.htm

[76] U.S. Department of State. (2011, November 29). Joint statement on the U.S.-EU Energy Council Ministerial (Media Note No. 2011/2018). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2011/11/177856.htm

positioned itself as a standard-setter, using regulatory cooperation and innovation talks to promote market liberalization and efficiency. Through targeted bilateral efforts, such as the MOUs with Poland[77] and Lithuania[78], the U.S. extended its presence in traditionally Russia-aligned regions through the promotion of energy diversification and non-Russian gas alternatives such as 'unconventional natural gas' (shale gas of the USA) and LNG. These ties were cast in the terms of 'capacity-building' and 'technical cooperation' to establish the legitimacy of American standards while undermining Russia's infrastructural monopolies.

Sanctions design, especially across Iran, exemplified how energy policy was facilitating greater strategic interest in containment. Discourse surrounding legal compliance and global responsibility justified measures taken by the United States to divorce firms such as Lukoil from Iranian markets, coercively targeting Russia and the preeminence of U.S.-delineated trade values[79] (continuing 2010 discourse and evading energy companies from cooperation with Iran). In the South, efforts like the Caribbean Renewable Energy Forum[80] and Libyan oil sales assistance[81] during the civil war showcased U.S. capacity to break up rival energy networks and emerge as a stabilizing broker. Emphasis on solar, geothermal, and regulatory reform served as a discursive counter-narrative to fossil-exporting regimes, a progressive narrative of decentralized, clean energy leadership. Generally, in 2011, U.S. foreign energy policy strategically exerted hard power (sanctions, legal weapons), soft power (norms, diplomacy through innovation), and market-reflective rhetoric in a campaign of reasserted leadership over an evolving world energy order. Russia did not show up as

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[77] U.S. Department of State. (2011, March 3). United States–Poland memorandum of understanding on cooperation in clean and efficient energy (Fact Sheet No. 2011/319). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2011/03/157600.htm

[78] U.S. Department of State. (2011, July 1). The United States and Lithuania strengthen energy security cooperation (Media Note No. 2011/1099). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2011/07/167474.htm

[79] U.S. Department of State. (2011, May 24). Companies reducing energy-related business with Iran (Fact Sheet No. 2011/818). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2011/05/164131.htm

[80] U.S. Department of State. (2011, October 12). U.S. delegation to the Caribbean Renewable Energy Forum (Media Note No. 2011/1709). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2011/10/175343.htm

[81] U.S. Department of State. (2011, June 20). Transitional National Council oil sales (Taken Question) (Taken Question No. 2011/1010). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2011/06/166573.htm

an overt adversary but structural competitor — fossil fuel based, centrally led model implicitly refuted by American visions of open, liberal, and green energy management.

In **2012**, out of 32 releases, 8 related to Russia. The United States employed a multifaceted strategy through a combination of sanctions, diplomacy, and institutional leadership. A major focus of U.S. influence was the isolation of Iran's energy sector. Through targeted sanctions and the enforcement of Section 1245 of the National Defense Authorization Act (NDAA), the U.S. incentivized[82] key importers (such as China, India, and Turkey) to reduce Iranian oil purchases, thus directly impacting Iran's revenue stream and reshaping global crude flows toward U.S. allies. All these anti-Iran actions are shaped under the issue of the Iranian nuclear program. Similar strategies were used to pressure corporate actors like Edison International to exit Iran's energy market[83], and to punish state-owned entities like Syria's Sytrol for engaging in Iran-linked energy trade[84]. The fourth U.S.-EU Energy Council[85] illustrates how the U.S. exercised regulatory and normative leadership by promoting transparent and secure energy markets, continuing support for European diversification via the Southern Gas Corridor, and encouraging the adoption of best practices in unconventional gas development. This aligned with a broader transatlantic effort to embed energy policy within institutional frameworks like the IEA, WTO, and EITI, reinforcing a neoliberal institutionalist approach.

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[82] U.S. Department of State. (2012, December 7). Regarding significant reductions of Iranian crude oil purchases (Press Statement No. 2012/1935, Hillary Rodham Clinton, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/20092013clinton/rm/2012/12/201683.htm

[83] U.S. Department of State. (2012, July 6). Withdrawal of Italian firm Edison International S.p.A. from Iran's energy sector (Press Statement No. 2012/1097, Victoria Nuland, Department Spokesperson). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2012/07/194650.htm

[84] U.S. Department of State. (2012, August 10). Syrian state-run oil company sanctioned under the Iran Sanctions Act (Press Statement No. 2012/1289, Patrick Ventrell, Acting Deputy Spokesperson). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2012/08/196258.htm

[85] U.S. Department of State. (2012, December 5). Joint statement on the U.S.-EU Energy Council (Media Note No. 2012/1917). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2012/12/201556.htm

Bilateral diplomacy also played a critical role. U.S. agreements with Australia[86], Georgia[87], and support for Sudan-South Sudan[88] oil negotiations reflect the use of strategic partnerships to secure supply routes, stabilize production regions, and promote U.S.-backed governance norms. At the same time, initiatives like the Energy and Climate Partnership of the Americas (ECPA) exemplified soft power tools to fund renewable energy, efficiency, and resilience projects in Latin America and the Caribbean[89], countering the influence of actors like Venezuela and China. U.S. energy diplomacy also extended to nuclear governance, exemplified by the appointment of Ambassador Joe Macmanus to the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)[90], where the U.S. sought to monitor Iran's compliance and maintain leadership in multilateral non-proliferation structures. Overall, the U.S. policies in 2012 blended competition and strategic alliances, norm promotion and institutional rule-making and cooperation. Sanctions, diplomatic pressure, multilateral frameworks, and development aid enabled the U.S. to maintain and extend its influence over both fossil fuel and emerging energy landscapes.

In **2013**, the United States adopted a multidimensional strategy, combining coercive economic tools, bilateral and multilateral partnerships, science diplomacy, and norm-setting mechanisms. Out of 36 press releases regarding energy, 10 were related to Russia. Most open U.S. tool of influence in 2013 remained its sanctions regime linked to energy for Iran under Section 1245 of NDAA that were used to

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[86] U.S. Department of State. (2012, November 15). Joint communique: Australia and United States – Resources and energy (Media Note No. 2012/1800). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2012/11/200570.htm

[87] U.S. Department of State. (2012, December 20). Joint statement of the U.S.-Georgia Strategic Partnership Commission Working Groups on Economic, Energy, and Trade and People-to-People and Cultural Exchanges (Media Note No. 2012/2009). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2012/12/202335.htm

[88] U.S. Department of State. (2012, August 4). Statement on the oil agreement between South Sudan and Sudan (Press Statement No. 2012/1268, Hillary Rodham Clinton, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/20092013clinton/rm/2012/08/196055.htm

[89] U.S. Department of State. (2012, December 11). U.S. supports "Sustainable Communities in Central America and the Caribbean" grants through the Energy and Climate Partnership of the Americas (ECPA) (Media Note No. 2012/1962). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2012/12/201804.htm

[90] U.S. Department of State. (2012, November 9). Secretary Clinton hosts the swearing-in ceremony for Joe Macmanus, U.S. Representative to the U.S. Mission to International Organizations in Vienna and the International Atomic Energy Agency (Remarks No. 2012/1772, Hillary Rodham Clinton, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/20092013clinton/rm/2012/11/200390.htm

acknowledge countries like China, India, South Korea, Turkey, and Japan that reduced or suspended their Iranian crude imports. The three instances when this was proclaimed during 2013 were March[91], June[92], and November.[93] The European Union was also portrayed as a reliable and disciplined partner in exerting economic pressure on Iran, reinforcing a discourse of transatlantic unity and shared commitment to enforcing non-proliferation norms. The sanctions were drafted with concerns over Iranian usage if nuclear for non peaceful purposes (terrorism), which securitized Iranian oil revenues as sponsoring terrorism. Such a framing legitimized the use of extra-territorial financial tools to sanction international energy flows — constituting a shift from traditional resource diplomacy to regulatory geopolitics. In particular, the U.S. cooperated very closely with the IAEA to support a verification mechanism that would enshrine Iran's compliance in international norms, further reinforcing the normative bases of its coercive campaign.

The U.S.-Russia energy cooperation was robust in 2013, institutionalized in the U.S.-Russia Bilateral Presidential Commission (BPC)[94]: it demonstrated pragmatic cooperation in energy-related science and infrastructure (and other issues such as Syria, Snowden, NATO). The Energy Working Group, co-chaired by U.S. Secretary of Energy Ernest Moniz and Russian Minister of Energy Alexander Novak, worked on several areas: smart grids and electric reliability (e.g., SDG&E collaboration with Belgorod's Helios lighting system), energy modeling and disaster resilience supported by Los Alamos National Laboratory, a clean energy R&D portfolio on nanotechnology, fuel cells, hydrogen storage, and biofuels and black carbon

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[91] U.S. Department of State. (2013, March 13). Regarding significant reductions of Iranian crude oil purchases (Press Statement No. 2013/0279, John Kerry, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2013/03/206125.htm

[92] U.S. Department of State. (2013, June 5). Regarding significant reductions of Iranian crude oil purchases (Press Statement No. 2013/0694, John Kerry, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2013/06/210321.htm

[93] U.S. Department of State. (2013, November 29). Regarding significant reductions of Iranian crude oil purchases (Remarks No. 2013/1496, John Kerry, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2013/11/218131.htm

[94] U.S. Department of State. (2013). U.S.-Russia Bilateral Presidential Commission: 2013 joint annual report. https://2009-2017.state.gov/p/eur/ci/rs/usrussiabilat/219086.htm#1

mitigation in the Arctic, including fieldwork in Murmansk. Such efforts reveal a two-level U.S. policy: first, to keep bilateral scientific cooperation as an instrument of influence and interdependence; second, to instill U.S. technical standards and governance practices into Russian energy modernization projects. Political relations deteriorated, but the U.S. used subnational and scientific diplomacy to condition the trajectory of Russian infrastructure and environmental regulation development. But this cooperation was coupled with strategic competition, most overtly visible in forums such as the NATO-Russia Council[95] and Kerry's repeated bilateral one-on-ones with Lavrov. In a December 2013 briefing, the U.S. pushed back against Lavrov's argument that developments in Iran made NATO's missile defense offers irrelevant by insisting again that ballistic missile systems (most commonly linked to WMD delivery) remained part of the broader energy-security equation. Thus, while technical collaboration persisted, strategic distrust and geopolitical differences along regional hydrocarbon conduits (i.e., Syria, Ukraine) were deepening. The December U.S.-Georgia Strategic Partnership Commission[96] reaffirmed Washington's support for Georgia's role as a transit country for Caspian hydrocarbons and its alignment with EU energy security interests in diversification. A U.S.-Pakistan energy trade mission coordinated U.S. firm cooperation with Pakistani oil and gas companies as a follow-up to consultations under Working Groups. USAID's installation of smart meters[97] and upgrading of transmission infrastructure was framed as one of the principal steps towards alleviating the energy crisis in Pakistan — highlighting not only America's role as donor, but technical standard-bearer and system changer. In Southeast Asia, the U.S.-Asia Pacific Comprehensive Energy Partnership (USACEP) symbolized U.S. efforts to redefine regional energy governance through clean energy

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[95] U.S. Department of State. (2013, December 5). Background briefing on the NATO-Russia meeting (Special Briefing No. 2013/T19-09, Senior State Department Officials). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2013/218355.htm

[96] U.S. Department of State. (2013, December 18). Joint statement of the U.S.-Georgia Strategic Partnership Commission Working Groups on Defense and Security; People-to-People and Cultural Exchanges; and Economic, Energy, and Trade (Media Note No. 2013/1600). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2013/218911.htm

[97] U.S. Department of State. (2013, August 1). Remarks at energy event (Remarks No. 2013/T11-04, John Kerry, Secretary of State, with Pakistani Minister of Power and Water Khawaja Asif). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2013/08/212617.htm

investment, interconnection, and gas market development. Activities included geothermal power development in Indonesia, wind power integration in Vietnam, and regional smart meter and grid code standards supported by OPIC, USTDA, and U.S. commercial actors[98]. The project blended economic statecraft and sustainable development against China's infrastructure diplomacy with a more decentralized, liberal model.

In addition to infrastructure and trade, the U.S. applied climate-coordinated soft power through energy influence. During the Greening Embassies Forum[99], Kerry connected energy efficiency and U.S. foreign policy identity, pledging sustainable transformation of U.S. foreign missions globally. Symbolic alignment between national and foreign energy conduct further solidified the U.S. role as a climate leader and environmental steward. Furthermore, the wPOWER[100] initiative advocated for gendered energy diplomacy, empowering over 8,000 women with clean energy entrepreneurship in East Africa, India, and Nigeria. The program not only enhanced access to clean technologies, but it also positioned women as agents of last-mile energy delivery—inserting U.S. power in emerging economies through bottom-up, community-based partnerships. It's a simple case of constructivist energy involvement, where identity, values, and empowerment are no less important than megawatts. In 2013, the United States embarked on a strategic transformation of global energy governance by acting at the same time through coercive instruments (sanctions and trade policy), cooperative institutionalized frameworks (e.g., BPC, USACEP, ECPA), and normative rhetoric (transparency, sustainability, gender equality).

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[98] U.S. Department of State. (2013, October 10). U.S.-Asia Pacific Comprehensive Energy Partnership (USACEP) (Fact Sheet No. 2013/1246). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2013/10/215267.htm

[99] U.S. Department of State. (2013, October 28). Secretary Kerry to deliver remarks at National Energy Action Month event (Notice to the Press No. 2013/1306). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2013/10/215947.htm

[100] U.S. Department of State. (2013, November 19). wPOWER: Promoting women's critical role in clean energy solutions to climate change (Fact Sheet No. 2013/1439). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2013/11/217737.htm

3.2 2014-2016: Crimean Crisis and Increases of LNG Exports

A key characteristic of the 2010s was the rise of the U.S. LNG exports**.** The development of LNG export infrastructure was a crucial component of this transformation. There were both economic as well as geopolitical motivations for the increase in the U.S.'s exporting activity, since it attempted to reduce Europe's dependency on Russian gas following the Ukraine crisis. The beginning of rapid development in LNG production can be attributed to Sabine Pass, Louisiana — the first facility to export liquefied natural gas, with its first shipment departing in February 2016. Operated by Cheniere Energy, the Sabine Pass LNG terminal has since expanded to include six fully operational liquefaction units, each capable of producing approximately 5 million tonnes per annum of LNG. This facility has set a precedent for subsequent LNG projects in the U.S (Cheniere Energy, n.d). As a result, the U.S. LNG export capacity more than tripled since 2018, with projections that it will nearly double by 2030 (IEA, 2024). The European Union became a key market for U.S. LNG, especially after the 2014 Ukraine crisis, which highlighted the risks of over-reliance on Russian gas. The U.S. actively supported European energy supplies diversification, insisting on the aggressive nature of the Russian state and framing Russia as an unreliable partner — securitisation mechanisms were put at work and LNG began to be considered a better alternative source of supply, enhancing Europe’s energy security. Countries like China, Japan, and South Korea emerged as significant buyers of U.S. LNG due to their growing energy demand and desire to diversify supply sources. Mexico relied on U.S. gas imports to meet domestic demand as well. Thereby, U.S. LNG became one of the key tools of U.S. foreign policy.

In **2014**, American energy diplomacy moved on three strategic fronts: countering Russian energy penetration in Europe, advancing international clean energy transition partnerships, and mainstreaming energy security into broader foreign policy frameworks. In response to the Crimean crisis, the U.S. openly put energy on

the table as a tool of coercion used by Moscow. A State Department fact sheet, "Russian Fiction the Sequel,"[101] showed that Russia increased prices of gas to Ukraine by 80%, utilizing energy interdependence as a punishment and weapon against Kiev's westward shift. In his March 26, 2014 speech in Brussels, President Barack Obama framed Russia's 'annexation of Crimea' not as the start of a new Cold War, but as a turning point for the international system — an act of unilateral violence that disregarded the post-World War II legal order (The Guardian, 2014). He ruled out any resort to military force, emphasizing instead the primacy of diplomacy, sanctions, and multilateral pressure. As he portrayed Russia as increasingly isolated, Obama stressed that economic and normative instruments alone would deliver lasting settlement. He equated energy policy with security, establishing clearly that American shale gas exports could allow Europe to end its reliance on Russian energy and therefore strip Moscow of its coercive influence (ibid.). He also urged Europe to undertake tough domestic transformations, like fracking, in order to develop native energy capacity (ibid.). Obama's discourse positioned the United States as a stabilizing power with liberal values and energy diversification as tools of strategic deterrence. The address thus marked the confluence of energy diplomacy and geopolitical containment in the West's new rhetoric vis-à-vis Russia. The April 5th U.S.-EU Energy Council[102] was the primary platform where Secretary John Kerry emphasized transatlantic partnership to be less reliant on Russian gas. The Council also supported new gas interconnections (e.g., Ukraine, Poland, Slovakia routes), LNG terminals, and the Southern Corridor project linking Azerbaijan to Europe. Kerry also emphasized the capacity of the U.S. to export more gas than what is being used in Europe today, taking advantage of approved export permits (U.S. Department of State, 2014).

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[101] U.S. Department of State. (2014, April 13). Russian fiction the sequel: 10 more false claims about Ukraine (Fact Sheet). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2014/04/224759.htm

[102] U.S. Department of State. (2014, April 2). Remarks at the U.S.-EU Energy Council Meeting (Remarks by John Kerry, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2014/04/224287.htm

In addition, on April 28, 2014, the U.S. Department of State imposed[103] export controls on high-technology defense articles to Russia and occupied Crimea. This was a historic coordination between arms control and energy sanctions tools, explicitly limiting Russia's dual-use capability under the U.S. Munitions List. Besides economic measures, the U.S. waged a war of words to discredit Russian actions. There was a series of fact sheets and media notes attributing to the Kremlin instigation of warfare via paramilitary proxies and propaganda. American documentation of Russian arms shipments, border incursions, and oil manipulation provided the foundation for an aggressive strategic communications effort aimed at shaping world public opinion[104]. The December 2014 Joint U.S.-EU Energy Council institutionalized further this agenda with an accord that energy must not be used 'as a political tool'[105]. It invoked the trilateral Ukraine gas agreement and mentioned U.S. and EU cooperation in order to enable Ukraine's integration into the EU energy market, promote domestic production, and expand renewables.

While confronting Russia, the U.S. also deepened bilateral and multilateral clean energy partnerships: with India[106] (expanded the Partnership to Advance Clean Energy (PACE) initiative, created the "Greening the Grid" project, and launched a $1B Ex-Im Bank MOU to finance solar exports); with China[107] (joint research on carbon capture, grid modernization, and low-carbon transport under the U.S.-China Climate Change Working Group); with Africa[108] (increased U.S.-ACEF funding to $30 million, enabling micro-grid, solar, and hydroelectric development that unlocked

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[103] U.S. Department of State. (2014, April 28). United States expands export restrictions on Russia (Press Statement, Jen Psaki, Department Spokesperson). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2014/04/225241.htm

[104] U.S. Department of State. (2014, July 14). Russia's continuing support for armed separatists in Ukraine and Ukraine's efforts toward peace, unity, and stability (Fact Sheet). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2014/07/229270.htm

[105] U.S. Department of State. (2014, December 3). Joint statement of the U.S.-EU Energy Council (Media Note). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2014/12/234638.htm

[106] U.S. Department of State. (2014, September 30). U.S.-India energy and climate change cooperation (Fact Sheet). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2014/09/232328.htm

[107] U.S. Department of State. (2014, July 9). Remarks at the top of the joint session on climate change and clean energy (Remarks by John Kerry, Secretary of State, with Vice Premier Wang Yang). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2014/07/228911.htm

[108] U.S. Department of State. (2014, August 7). State Department to invest $10 million to extend the U.S.-Africa Clean Energy Finance Initiative (Media Note). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2014/230393.htm

hundreds of millions in private investment); with the Caribbean and Eastern Mediterranean (piloted regulatory reforms in Grenada[109] and enabled natural gas exports from Noble Energy to Jordan[110], reinforcing U.S. presence in volatile regions). In sum, Russia was consistently depicted as a revisionist actor leveraging its resource endowment for geopolitical purposes, while the U.S. has become a provider of resilience — offering infrastructure funding, LNG exports, regulatory assistance, and diplomatic support to both Europe and emerging markets.

During **2015**, the U.S. government utilized strategic energy diplomacy in an attempt to build alliances, assist clean energy transitions, and limit competitors — primarily Russia. A key innovation was the launch of the Climate and Clean Energy Investment Forum, co-hosted with Google and Georgetown University. The forum placed investment as a policy and discursive lever, framing U.S. public-private partnerships as scalable alternatives to state-led energy models like Russia's Gazprom. Investment instruments included USAID's CEFF-CCA and OPIC's $400 million support of South African CSP projects[111]. This discourse framed energy not simply as a commodity, but as a tool of resilience, climate diplomacy, and democratic development — implicitly contrasting with Russia's weaponization of hydrocarbons. A number of statements directly condemned Russian interference in Ukraine and energy manipulation. The U.S.-Ukraine Energy Security Dialogue[112] acknowledged technical and financial support for gas diversification, Naftogaz reform, and electricity production — a unification of Ukraine's autonomy from Russian fuel sources. Simultaneously, the U.S. actively delegitimized Russia's law and influence

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[109] U.S. Department of State. (2014, September 3). United States and Grenada sign memorandum of understanding on energy security (Media Note). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2014/09/231258.htm

[110] U.S. Department of State. (2014, September 4). The State Department welcomes the signing of a letter of intent between Noble Energy, other Leviathan partners, and National Electric Power Company of Jordan (Media Note). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2014/09/231284.htm

[111] U.S. Department of State. (2015, October 21). Commitments at the Secretary's Climate and Clean Energy Investment Forum (Fact Sheet). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2015/10/248412.htm

[112] U.S. Department of State. (2015, July 14). United States - Ukraine Energy Security Working Group (Media Note). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2015/07/244892.htm

efforts, like the 'Undesirables' Law[113] used to push out NGOs such as the Open Society Foundations. These actions extended U.S. influence not only in the energy sector but also into the broader arena of civil society and dominance over information space. A background briefing on ISIL oil revenues[114] directly refuted Russian claims that Turkey had been engaged in illicit oil trade. U.S. officials provided technical refutations of Russia's satellite imagery, depriving Moscow of its moral authority while reasserting U.S. commitment to tracking and disabling ISIL sources of revenue through oil infrastructure targeting. Additionally, in upper-level interactions between Kerry and Lavrov/Putin[115], U.S. rhetoric[116] paired Russia's strategic behaviors (e.g. air strikes, energy deals, Ukrainian destabilization) with the imperative of rule-based solutions — emphasizing UN processes, ceasefire monitoring, and constitutional reform over unilateral energy sway.

In **2016**, U.S. foreign energy policy deepened its two-track strategy: encouraging energy security and climate cooperation with allies and partners and employing institutional, financial, and discursive instruments to influence international norms of energy governance. In the U.S.-EU Energy Council[117] the U.S. called for LNG diversification, interconnection projects (like TAP and the Greece-Bulgaria Interconnector), and regulatory harmonization to reduce European dependence on Russian gas — consistent U.S. use of security language, such as rejecting 'energy as a political weapon' particularly in relation to Russia and projects

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[113] U.S. Department of State. (2015, November 30). Designation under Russia's "Undesirables" law of the Open Society Foundations (Press Statement, Mark C. Toner, Deputy Department Spokesperson). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2015/11/250158.htm

[114] U.S. Department of State. (2015, December 4). Background briefing on ISIL and oil (Special Briefing by a Senior State Department Official). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2015/12/250383.htm

[115] U.S. Department of State. (2015, December 15). Remarks with Russian President Vladimir Putin (Remarks by John Kerry, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2015/12/250661.htm

[116] U.S. Department of State. (2015, December 15). Interview with Sergey Brilev of Rossiya 1 (Interview by John Kerry, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2015/12/250683.htm

[117] U.S. Department of State. (2016, May 4). U.S.-EU Energy Council (Media Note). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2016/05/256883.htm

like Nord Stream 2[118]. The June 8 U.S.-China Strategic and Economic Dialogue[119] marked a paradigm shift: climate and energy diplomacy became the tools of global strategic leadership. The twin backing of the two countries of ETS development, management of transport sector emissions, and reforming the Montreal Protocol HFC made both of them the co-managers of the low-carbon transition. Multilevel governance (national, subnational, and private) aided America's desires for polycentric leadership. In the U.S.-Caribbean and Central American Energy Summit[120] and U.S.-Guatemala Energy Dialogue[121], Washington promoted regional energy integration, particularly through transborder interconnection and the use of natural gas. They were neoliberal integration model-based, coupling market deregulation with restructuring of the regulatory system. Kerry linked energy modernization with democratization and stability, thus locating it as part of deeper goals of democratization. In Africa, the U.S.-Angola Strategic Energy Dialogue[122] emphasized regulatory improvement and environmental performance.

Energy politics remained at the center of the Syrian conflict. U.S.-Russia talks repeatedly evoked humanitarian access and civilian infrastructure protection, both of which cover critical energy infrastructure (water, electricity, fuel convoys). The U.S. positioned itself as a humanitarian norm-defender and Russia as blocking, leading to the October closure of bilateral Syria channels[123]. The U.S.-Cuba Renewable Energy

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[118] U.S. Department of State. (2016, May 4). Remarks with EU High Representative Federica Mogherini, Secretary of Energy Ernest Moniz (Remarks by John Kerry, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2016/05/256882.htm

[119] U.S. Department of State. (2016, June 8). Climate change and clean energy at the 2016 U.S.-China Strategic and Economic Dialogue (Fact Sheet). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2016/06/258178.htm

[120] U.S. Department of State. (2016, May 3). Remarks at the Council of the Americas' 46th Annual Washington Conference of the Americas / U.S.-Caribbean-Central American Energy Summit Reception (Remarks by John Kerry, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2016/05/256843.htm

[121] U.S. Department of State. (2016, October 13). U.S.-Guatemala Energy Policy Dialogue in Washington (Media Note). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2016/10/263092.htm

[122] U.S. Department of State. (2016, August 1). U.S.-Angola Strategic Energy Dialogue in Washington (Media Note). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2016/08/260727.htm

[123] U.S. Department of State. (2016, October 3). Suspension of participation in bilateral channels with Russia established to sustain the cessation of hostilities in Syria (Press Statement, John Kirby, Assistant Secretary and Department Spokesperson, Bureau of Public Affairs). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2016/10/262704.htm

and Efficiency Working Group[124] launch exemplified energy as a low-risk field for bilateral confidence-building and cooperative functional relations. The Major Economies Forum[125] and Our Ocean Conference[126] promoted U.S. leadership in the field of environmental security. Kerry and Novelli made the link between climate, conflict, migration, and economic vulnerability — the reframing of mitigation and ocean conservation as strategic imperatives. Both events were instances of whole-of-society diplomacy, engaging the youth, civil society, and industry in the foreign policymaking process, thereby increasing U.S. influence through network governance.

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[124] U.S. Department of State. (2016, December 14). U.S.-Cuba Renewable Energy and Energy Efficiency Working Group (Media Note). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2016/12/265643.htm

[125] U.S. Department of State. (2016, September 23). Remarks at the Major Economies Forum on Energy and Climate (Remarks by John Kerry, Secretary of State). https://2009-2017.state.gov/secretary/remarks/2016/09/262340.htm

[126] U.S. Department of State. (2016, September 14). Under Secretary of State for Economic Growth, Energy, and the Environment Catherine Novelli on the 2016 Our Ocean Conference (Special Briefing by Catherine A. Novelli). https://2009-2017.state.gov/r/pa/prs/ps/2016/09/261915.htm

3.3 2017-2021: Trump Administration, Energy Independence and Energy Dominance

The 2017-2021 was an assertive period, where the instruments of hard power and soft power were employed. In 2017, President Donald Trump redefined the direction of U.S. energy policy by introducing the concept of 'energy dominance,' a term aimed at distinguishing his administration's agenda from Obama's. Trump announced a 'golden era' of American energy: it was about to be driven by increased fossil fuel production and the increased export of coal, oil, and LNG, especially to markets in Eastern Europe and Asia (DiChristopher, 2017). Energy Secretary Rick Perry defined energy dominance as: "An energy dominant America means self-reliant. It means a secure nation, free from the geopolitical turmoil of other nations who seek to use energy as an economic weapon." and "An energy dominant America will export to markets around the world, increasing our global leadership and our influence."[127] These citations were published by CNBC on July 1 of 2017. Critics, however, questioned the coherence of this strategy, pointing to Trump's simultaneous cuts to clean energy R&D and his withdrawal from the Paris Agreement, which undercut the global credibility of U.S. leadership in sustainable energy (ibid.). Overall, during President Donald Trump the United States used sanctions, diplomatic pressure, encouragement of LNG exports, and strategic framing of Russian energy as a threat to trigger Europe's exit from reliance on Russia.

In practical terms, 2017 saw the U.S. begin ramping up exports of LNG to overseas markets. U.S. LNG exports quadrupled from 2016 levels to reach about 1.94 billion cubic feet per day in 2017[128], with cargoes reaching 25 countries across Asia, Europe, the Middle East, and the Americas. Notably, Europe emerged as a growing

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[127] DiChristopher, T. (2017, July 1). Trump wants America to be 'energy dominant.' Here's what that means. CNBC. https://www.cnbc.com/2017/06/28/trump-america-energy-dominant-policy.html

[128] U.S. Energy Information Administration. (2018, March 27). U.S. liquefied natural gas exports quadrupled in 2017. https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=35512#:~:text=U.S.%20exports%20of%20liquefied%20natural,0.5%20Bcf%2Fd%20in%202016

destination (the third-largest regional importer of U.S. LNG in 2017), reflecting initial transatlantic objectives of diversifying gas supplies, according to EIA (2018). Even as the United States promoted its LNG as a source of 'freedom' and security, it simultaneously employed hard power measures against Russian energy ventures. In August 2017, Congress passed and President Trump signed the Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA). This sweeping sanctions law — a response to Russian 'interference' in Ukraine and the 2016 U.S. election — explicitly targeted Russia's energy sector and threatened secondary sanctions on foreign companies assisting Russian export pipelines. CAATSA's Section 257 on Ukrainian energy security identified projects like Nord Stream 2 as a particular concern that threatens energy security of Europe. It is states that it is the policy of the USA 'to help Ukraine and United States allies and partners in Europe reduce their dependence on Russian energy resources, especially natural gas, which the Government of the Russian Federation uses as a weapon to coerce, intimidate, and influence other countries'[129] — very clear anti-Russian discourse positioning it as an aggressor state that weaponizes its energy industry against European countries. The law thus represented an early hard-power instrument to disable Moscow's energy ambitions and support Europe's energy diversification (even as its implementation would be calibrated in deference to European sensitivities). Diplomatically, 2017 also saw high-profile U.S. efforts to encourage European nations to buy American energy. In July, President Trump visited Poland and the Three Seas Initiative summit[130], where he praised Poland for receiving its first U.S. LNG shipment that month and promised that the United States could provide Central Europe with alternative fuel. In Warsaw, Trump vowed 'America stands ready to help Poland and other European nations

[129] U.S. Congress. (2017). Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act, Pub. L. No. 115–44, 131 Stat. 886. https://www.congress.gov/115/plaws/publ44/PLAW-115publ44.pdf

[130] The White House. (2017, July 6). Remarks by President Trump at the Three Seas Initiative Summit. https://2017-2021-translations.state.gov/2017/07/06/remarks-by-president-trump-at-the-three-seas-initiative-summit-july-6-2017/

diversify their energy supplies'[131], so that they are 'never again held hostage to a single supplier or nation'[132] — a clear reference to Russia. The Polish leadership, for its part, welcomed the U.S. LNG as a vehicle for supply diversification, with President Andrzej Duda hailing the inaugural cargo and expressing hope for long-term contracts to import U.S. gas as a way to reduce Poland's reliance on Russian imports. Through such soft-power signaling and LNG diplomacy, the U.S. began to frame itself as the reliable partner enabling Europe's 'gas freedom,' in contrast to the coercive supplier in Moscow.

In **2018**, the U.S. escalated its campaign both rhetorically and diplomatically to persuade European allies to rethink their dependence on Russian energy. A pivotal moment came at the NATO summit in July 2018, when President Trump publicly warned Germany for the Nord Stream 2 pipeline. In an unusually blunt critique delivered at a televised breakfast with NATO's Secretary General, Trump claimed "Germany is totally controlled by Russia"[133] because of its heavy reliance on Russian gas, noting "they will be getting 60 to 70 percent of their energy from Russia" via the new pipeline (Trump, 2018) as cited in PBS News. He questioned how Germany could be secure while its energy lifeline was in Putin's hands, calling the situation "inappropriate" and "a very bad thing for NATO" (ibid.). This very public claim — albeit with exaggerated figures — underscored the U.S. narrative that Russian energy projects like Nord Stream 2 were undermining European security from within. Washington was effectively securitizing energy in the transatlantic discourse, framing gas pipelines as strategic threats. Concurrently, the Trump administration pursued a more cooperative avenue with the EU to promote U.S. LNG. On July 25, 2018, President Trump and European Commission President Jean-Claude Juncker reached a

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[131] The White House. (2017, July 6). The President's news conference with President Andrzej Duda of Poland in Warsaw, Poland. https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/DCPD-201700549/html/DCPD-201700549.htm

[132] DiChristopher, T. (2017, July 6). Trump pitches US natural gas to European leaders, suggests Russian gas holds them hostage. CNBC. https://www.cnbc.com/2017/07/06/trump-natural-gas-europe-leaders.html

[133] PBS NewsHour. (2018, July 11). At NATO, Trump says Germany is 'totally controlled by Russia'. https://www.pbs.org/newshour/politics/at-nato-trump-says-germany-is-totally-controlled-by-russia

surprise joint announcement to defuse a possible trade war. As part of the resulting U.S.-EU deal, the European Union agreed to "strengthen its strategic cooperation with the U.S. on energy"[134] and expressed intent to import more American LNG to diversify its supplies (European Commission, 2018). Trump claimed that the EU would become a "massive buyer of LNG"[135] from the United States and that America would make it easier for Europe to access this fuel (The White House, 2018). The joint statement explicitly noted the EU's desire to "import more liquefied natural gas from the United States to diversify [its] energy supply", aligning with a core U.S. objective (ibid.). Following this agreement, U.S. officials and embassies in Europe actively promoted LNG trade. EU imports of U.S. LNG did increase markedly - by over 180% year-on-year — in the wake of these political commitments (EU Commission, 2019). The energy cooperation pledge of 2018 thus represented U.S. economic statecraft at work: America leveraged its trade negotiations to open markets for its gas, reinforcing Europe's turn toward supply diversification.

U.S. diplomacy in 2018 also targeted specific regions and projects to counter Russian influence. The State Department's energy envoys and the Department of Energy pressed Eastern Mediterranean and Balkan countries to pursue alternatives to Russian gas. For instance, in Greece and Croatia, the U.S. advocated for LNG terminals and new interconnectors (such as the Krk island LNG terminal and the Greece-Bulgaria interconnector) with the promise that the U.S. LNG could be part of the supply mix. In September 2018, at the Three Seas Initiative summit in Bucharest, U.S. Energy Secretary Rick Perry declared support for Central European infrastructure that would allow American gas to flow north-south. During visits to countries like Hungary, Ukraine, and Poland, Secretary Perry consistently hammered

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[134] European Commission. (2018, July 25). Joint U.S.-EU statement following President Juncker's visit to the White House. [Press release]. https://www.eeas.europa.eu/node/48865_fr

[135] The White House (2018, July 25). Remarks by President Trump and President Juncker of the European Commission in Joint Press Statements. https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefings-statements/remarks-president-trump-president-juncker-european-commission-joint-press-statements/

home Washington's message about the Kremlin's energy coercion. "We should no longer allow the Kremlin to use energy as a weapon,"[136] Perry warned on a trip to Budapest in November 2018, stressing the need for Central Europe to diversify away from Russian gas (Reuters, 2018). This forceful informational framing by a senior U.S. official reinforced the securitization narrative: Russia's pipeline projects were cast as geopolitical aggressions, while U.S. energy exports were framed as liberating allies.

By **2019**, American LNG exports surged to record highs in 2019, and the U.S. government promoted these exports as a force for good. In a famous Department of Energy press release in May 2019, officials rebranded natural gas in ideological terms: the DOE called increased LNG export capacity as critical to "spreading freedom gas throughout the world by giving America's allies a diverse and affordable source of clean energy"[137] (DOE, 2019). The press release even referred to gas molecules as "molecules of U.S. freedom" being sent abroad. This deliberate messaging strategy framed U.S. energy as not just a commodity but a symbol of liberal values and liberation from authoritarian influence — soft power in the energy domain. Beyond Europe, the U.S. also pushed this narrative in Asia, promoting American LNG to Japan, South Korea, and others as a reliable alternative to regional competitors. By positioning itself as the arsenal of energy democracy, the U.S. aimed to win hearts and minds and secure long-term markets for its exports.

On the hard-power front, 2019 was a watershed year because the United States took direct aim at the completion of Nord Stream 2. After diplomatic warning and threats failed to slow the project, the U.S. Congress passed the Protecting Europe's

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[136] Reuters. (2018, November 13). Russia should not be allowed to use energy as a weapon – Perry. https://www.reuters.com/article/hungary-us-energy/russia-should-not-be-allowed-to-use-energy-as-a-weapon-perry-idINL8N1XO6HH/

[137] U.S. Department of Energy. (2019, May 29). Department of Energy authorizes additional LNG exports from Freeport LNG. https://www.energy.gov/articles/department-energy-authorizes-additional-lng-exports-freeport-lng

Energy Security Act (PEESA)[138] — as a part of National Defense Authorization Act for FY2020. It mandated sanctions on any vessel engaged in pipe-laying for Nord Stream 2 (or TurkStream), effectively targeting the specialty contractors needed to finish the Baltic Sea pipeline. President Trump signed these sanctions into law in December 2019. The impact was immediate: within days, the Swiss contractor Allseas, which was laying the pipes, suspended its operations to avoid U.S. punishment. Construction of Nord Stream 2 ground to a halt with roughly 160 kilometers left unfinished. The U.S. had successfully imposed a de facto veto on a key Russian-European energy link, demonstrating Washington's willingness to use legal-regulatory tools in support of its strategic aims. Strategically, the 2019 pipeline sanctions sent a powerful signal well beyond Nord Stream 2. They conveyed to both European governments and private companies that the United States would intervene — even at the cost of friction with allies like Germany — to block energy projects it deemed threats to allied security. It reinforced the credibility of U.S. commitment to Central and Eastern Europe's energy security, bolstering those countries' bargaining position inside the EU. From Moscow's perspective, these sanctions underscored the need to seek alternative markets and routes (which Russia accelerated by pivoting to China and Turkey for gas exports). Indeed, December 2019 also saw the inauguration of the Power of Siberia pipeline that delivers Russian gas to China — called by Putin as the start of Russia's 'Pivot to Asia' — partly reflecting Russia's response to challenges in the west. Thus, even as the U.S. assisted Europe's pivot away from Russia, Russia began diversifying toward Asian markets, a development outside the U.S.-EU theater but indicative of global consequences.

In addition, in 2019, the United States utilized its energy influence elsewhere globally, piling up influence with sanctions on competitive producers. Specifically,

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[138] U.S. Congress. (2019). H.R.3206 – Protecting Europe's Energy Security Act of 2019, 116th Cong. https://www.congress.gov/bill/116th-congress/house-bill/3206/text

sweeping sanctions on Venezuela's state oil company (PdVSA)[139], constraining one of Russia's allied shippers of oil and redirecting some supply chains. These hard-power moves tightened global supply and indirectly increased demand for U.S. oil and that of its partners. By the end of 2019, American oil output reached an all-time high (over 12 million barrels per day) (EIA, 2019) and U.S. crude exports hit record levels, some of which went to Europe to replace sanctioned barrels. In fact, as mentioned in the beginning of the chapter, 2019 marked the first time in 67 years that the United States exported more total energy than it imported, symbolically achieving a form of 'energy independence' that successive presidents had sought. This newfound position of strength enabled the U.S. to act as a swing player in global energy geopolitics — from Europe to Asia and Latin America — by flexing sanctions and offering supply. Still, the U.S. approach was not purely self-serving; American officials framed these actions as aligning economic interests with a principled stand for a free and secure energy order.

The year **2020** brought unprecedented turbulence to energy markets with the COVID-19 pandemic, yet the United States maintained its strategic push on energy security issues. The pandemic-triggered collapse in oil and gas demand led to temporary oversupply and historically low prices, testing the viability of the U.S. shale industry. The Trump administration stayed focused on countering Russian energy influence. In fact, as Russia and Germany attempted to circumvent U.S. sanctions to complete Nord Stream 2, Washington doubled down on its hard-power measures. In July 2020, U.S. Secretary of State Mike Pompeo announced the termination of a sanctions waiver that had previously spared Nord Stream 2 from certain CAATSA penalties. Pompeo updated the public guidance on CAATSA to explicitly include Nord Stream 2 and the second line of TurkStream, warning

[139] U.S. Department of the Treasury. (2019, January 28). Treasury sanctions Venezuela's state-owned oil company Petroleos de Venezuela, S.A. https://home.treasury.gov/news/press-releases/sm594

companies aiding those projects to "get out now or risk the consequences"[140]. The strategic effect was to delay the pipeline further and to raise the political costs for Germany and Russia. Alongside sanctions, the U.S. in 2020 increased diplomatic coordination with European partners to manage the fallout and maintain pressure on Russia. The State Department and Congress engaged in intensive dialogue with Germany, trying to convince Berlin to pause or cancel Nord Stream 2. Although Germany publicly protested against U.S. extraterritorial sanctions as interference, it also began hedging; i.e., German authorities discussed national and EU regulatory alternatives that would limit Gazprom's control over the pipeline if constructed. The United States could count on steadfast support from Poland and the Baltic states, which together comprised a de facto coalition with Washington against Nord Stream 2. Apart from that, U.S. diplomacy highlighted alternatives to Europe: officials pushed the Southern Gas Corridor, which in 2020 was nearing completion to bring Azerbaijani gas to Italy, and they peddled new U.S. LNG trades (indeed, U.S. LNG exports to Europe did continue, and volumes later in the year rebounded as prices did). Even through the pandemic, U.S. LNG exports held up — flexible U.S. cargoes assisted in refilling European gas storage by late 2020, demonstrating the merit of having the U.S. as a supplier in times of volatility. Such market-driven confidence reinforced the diplomatic message that Europe would be more secure with diversified supplies.

U.S. policy in 2020 also paid attention to Asia and other regions: Asia EDGE (Enhancing Development and Growth through Energy)[141], prepared in mid-2018, gained momentum by 2020. Through Asia EDGE, the U.S. worked with countries like India, Japan, and Vietnam to promote sustainable and secure energy markets — implicitly encouraging them to choose U.S. LNG, renewables, and nuclear technology

[140] U.S. Department of State. (2020, July 15). Secretary Michael R. Pompeo at a press availability (Remarks by Michael R. Pompeo, Secretary of State, and Francis R. Fannon, Assistant Secretary, Bureau of Energy Resources). https://2017-2021.state.gov/secretary-michael-r-pompeo-at-a-press-availability-9/

[141] U.S. Department of State. (n.d.). Asia EDGE – Enhancing Development and Growth through Energy. https://2017-2021.state.gov/asia-edge/

over Chinese or Russian options. In February 2020, the U.S. and India upgraded their Strategic Energy Partnership[142], with India agreeing to greater U.S. oil and LNG imports, thereby reducing its reliance on Middle Eastern and Russian sources. In Latin America, the U.S. continued attempts to isolate Venezuela and its oil regime and instead deepened cooperation in energy with Brazil, Colombia, and others aligned with U.S. interests. The U.S. hard power tools were still evolving to meet the perceived challenge from Russian energy projects. In parallel, however, there was recognition in Washington that European allies' own decisions would ultimately dictate outcomes. As one State Department official acknowledged, Nord Stream 2 was over 90% built by the time the U.S. fully engaged, making "stopping it a long shot"[143]. This pragmatic note hinted at the limits of U.S. influence and set the stage for a rethinking under the upcoming Biden administration.

In **2021**, U.S. policy on global energy markets saw a transition with the change in administration, but many underlying objectives remained consistent. President Joe Biden took office in January 2021 with a priority to "rehabilitating frayed alliances"[144], especially with core EU partners like Germany, even as he shared his predecessor's skepticism of Russian energy projects. The Biden administration immediately continued to oppose Nord Stream 2 but with a task to not undermine the U.S.-German relationship. This led to a use of both hard and soft power. In May 2021, the State Department issued a report identifying the company building Nord Stream 2 (Nord Stream 2 AG) and its CEO as engaged in sanctionable activity, yet Secretary Blinken simultaneously waived those particular sanctions, citing U.S. national

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[142] The White House. (2020, February 25). Joint statement: Vision and principles for the United States-India comprehensive global strategic partnership. https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefings-statements/joint-statement-vision-principles-united-states-india-comprehensive-global-strategic-partnership/

[143] Shalal, Gardner, & Holland (2021, May 19). U.S. waives sanctions on Nord Stream 2 as Biden seeks to mend Europe ties. Reuters. https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/us-waive-sanctions-firm-ceo-behind-russias-nord-stream-2-pipeline-source-2021-05-19/

[144] Atlantic Council. (2020, August 21). Adviser on Biden's foreign policy: Start at home and repair alliances. https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/blogs/new-atlanticist/adviser-on-bidens-foreign-policy-start-at-home-and-repair-alliances/

interests (to maintain unity with Germany) (Shalal, Gardner, & Holland, 2021). This controversial decision essentially conceded that the pipeline would be completed, but sought to preserve leverage and goodwill for the post-completion phase. At the same time, the U.S. did impose sanctions on a number of Russian vessels and firms involved in the construction, to signal continued disapproval. The mixed approach reflected an attempt at coercive diplomacy: using enough sanctions to emphasize U.S. opposition, while using waivers as an olive branch to Germany. Over the summer of 2021, intensive U.S.-German negotiations culminated in a Joint Statement on Nord Stream 2[145]. In this agreement, Germany pledged to take national-level action (including potential sanctions) if Russia used energy as a weapon or committed further aggression against Ukraine, and it committed funding to help Ukraine's energy transition and security. The United States, in turn, accepted the completion of Nord Stream 2 but stressed that the pipeline should not be allowed to endanger Europe's security. Essentially, the U.S. leveraged soft power and alliance relations to extract German commitments that aligned with the original goal of protecting Ukraine and limiting Putin's leverage. While some Eastern European nations were unhappy with this compromise, it demonstrated Washington's recognition that European interests mattered — the EU's largest economy had to be on board to truly counter Russian energy influence. The joint statement also showed a U.S. shift toward multilateralizing the response (making it a Western consensus to deter Russia's energy coercion, rather than a unilateral U.S. campaign).

Beyond the Nord Stream saga, the U.S. in 2021 continued to promote energy diversification and climate-security initiatives. The Biden administration rejoined the Paris Climate Agreement and U.S. officials continued supporting the Three Seas Initiative and other European efforts to build gas interconnections and LNG terminals. During 2021's global gas supply crunch (when post-COVID demand spiked and

[145] Federal Foreign Office of Germany. (2021, July 21). Joint statement of the US and Germany on support for Ukraine, European energy security, and our climate goals [Press release]. https://www.auswaertiges-amt.de/en/newsroom/news/joint-statement-usa-and-germany/2472084

European spot gas prices hit record highs), the U.S. urged Russia to increase gas supplies to Europe and "do more to ensure European energy security"[146]. American and EU politicians argued that Gazprom's failure to ship adequate gas exacerbated Europe's energy crisis[147] — reinforcing the U.S. narrative that Russia was willing to "weaponize" energy by exploiting European problems for political gain. At that time 40% of gas was imported from Russia in the EU and 60% of imported gas was used to power houses and factories (The Moscow Times, 2021). These events set the stage for a transatlantic alignment: by late 2021, EU member states were far more vocal about the risks of over-reliance on Russian gas.

On the global stage, the U.S. also underscored its role as a supplier of last resort. By December 2021, the United States had become the world's largest LNG exporter on a monthly basis, with massive volumes flowing to Asia (particularly China, South Korea, and Japan) where gas demand was surging. This made the U.S. a critical player in balancing Asia-Europe gas dynamics: for instance, when Asian buyers bid away LNG cargoes, Europe faced shortages — a predicament that highlighted the interdependence of Atlantic and Pacific energy security. The U.S. also convened the Quad energy working group[148] (with India, Japan, Australia) to ensure that Indo-Pacific allies support decarbonization efforts.

In sum, the 2017-2021 period saw the United States reassert itself as a central actor in global energy geopolitics, employing a wide array of instruments to steer allies away from Russian energy dependence and toward a diversified, U.S.-inclusive supply structure. Washington's use of hard power (e.g. sanctions on pipelines), soft power (high-level diplomacy and normative framing), economic leverage (LNG

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[146] U.S. Embassy in Russia. (2021, October 14). Deputy Secretary Sherman's meeting with Russian Deputy Prime Minister Overchuk [Readout]. U.S. Embassy in Russia. https://ru.usembassy.gov/deputy-secretary-sherman-meeting-with-russian-deputy-prime-minister-overchuk-101421/

[147] The Moscow Times. (2021, September 21). Gazprom rejects gas transit increase as Europe faces winter fuel crisis. https://www.themoscowtimes.com/2021/09/21/gazprom-rejects-gas-transit-increase-as-europe-faces-winter-fuel-crisis-a75098

[148] Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan. (2021, September 24). Fact sheet: Quad Leaders' Summit. https://www.mofa.go.jp/files/100238181.pdf

export capacity and finance), legal-regulatory action (domestic laws with extraterritorial impact), and information campaigns (publicly branding Russian energy as a threat) was largely effective in reshaping the conversation and, to a degree, outcomes in Europe's energy pivot. By 2021, the EU was more actively pursuing energy security measures long advocated by the U.S., such as building LNG terminals, enacting stricter regulations on pipeline ownership, and integrating its gas networks. At the same time, the limits of U.S. influence were evident: some projects (like Nord Stream 2) moved forward due to strong vested interests in Europe, reminding that Europe's own calculations (economic costs, political trade-offs) could override U.S. preferences. In essence, U.S. influence was significant but not solely deterministic. It worked best in synergy with European stakeholders who shared American threat perceptions, and it encountered pushback when U.S. tactics were seen as too unilateral.

3.4 2022-2024: LNG Leadership

The year 2022 began with continued concerns of Western hemisphere over the Ukraine situation and Russian mobilisation of resources near borders, which was named a "deeply troubling build-up"[149]. Secretary Blinken in January 2022 claimed that Nord Stream operation is strongly opposed by the USA as it "undermined Europe's energy security"[150], especially damaging Ukraine by depriving it of potential transit fees economic benefit, as pipeline bypasses Ukraine's territory. In general in many statements[151] by U.S. officials there is a discourse of calling Russia to diplomatic resolution of the Ukraine conflict (before actual aggression), referring to difficulties of Ukraine and European energy security as a whole[152]. Many arguments[153] were based on positioning Russia as a liar and not a credible partner that does not deserve any trust, but only spreads misinformation about its history and problems of people of Donbas[154]. Russia is framed as a dangerous adversary that destabilizes neighbours internal affairs and undermines sovereignty[155], these claims are supported by recalling Russian 'interference' in U.S. 2016 elections, of which Russia is still accused by the USA, despite absence of factual proof. Blinken continuously claimed NATO to be a defensive alliance that 'didn't invade Georgia… didn't invade Ukraine.

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[149] U.S. Department of State. (2022, January 18). Secretary Blinken's call with Russian Foreign Minister Lavrov [Readout]. https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-blinkens-call-with-russian-foreign-minister-lavrov-5/

[150] U.S. Department of State. (2022, January 19). Secretary Antony J. Blinken with Myroslava Gongadze of Voice of America's Ukrainian Service (Interview by Myroslava Gongadze, Voice of America). https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-antony-j-blinken-with-myroslava-gongadze-of-voice-of-americas-ukrainian-service/

[151] U.S. Department of State. (2022, January 19). Secretary Antony J. Blinken to Mission Ukraine staff (Remarks by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-antony-j-blinken-to-mission-ukraine-staff/

[152] U.S. Department of State. (2022, January 19). Secretary Antony J. Blinken and Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy before their meeting (Remarks by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-antony-j-blinken-and-ukrainian-president-volodymyr-zelenskyy-before-their-meeting/

[153] U.S. Department of State. (2022, January 20). Russia's top five persistent disinformation narratives (Fact Sheet). https://2021-2025.state.gov/russias-top-five-persistent-disinformation-narratives/

[154] U.S. Department of State. (2022, January 20). Fact vs. fiction: Russian disinformation on Ukraine (Fact Sheet). https://2021-2025.state.gov/fact-vs-fiction-russian-disinformation-on-ukraine/

[155] U.S. Department of State. (2022, January 20). Taking action to expose and disrupt Russia's destabilization campaign in Ukraine (Press Statement by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/taking-action-to-expose-and-disrupt-russias-destabilization-campaign-in-ukraine/

Russia did.'[156] Despite the fact that it is NATO that invaded Kosovo (1999) and Libya (2011), gave membership to post-Soviet Estonia, Latvia, Lithuania (2004) and did offer membership to Georgia and Ukraine, interfering into Russian sphere of regional influence and provoking corresponding reaction.

The February 2022 Joint Statement of the U.S.-EU Energy Council emphasizes 'resilience,' 'partnership,' and a 'just energy transition'[157]. The U.S. framed itself as Europe's guarantor of energy security in the face of Russian coercion, advocating for supply diversification, and infrastructure synchronization with Ukraine and Moldova. Simultaneously, it promoted liberal energy governance norms — such as regulatory transparency and market integration — particularly in Eastern Europe and the Western Balkans, thereby linking decarbonization to democratic reform. Antony J. Blinken claimed in a talk with Vice President of the European Commission Josep Borrell, and European Commissioner for Energy Kadri Simson at the U.S.-EU Energy Council Ministerial: "At precisely the time Europe most needs a stable energy supply to get people through the winter, Russia has attempted to increase its energy leverage"[158], and Borrell supported it: 'Russia don't hesitate on using the energy supplies to Europe as a weapon for geopolitical gain'. These statements frame Russia as an aggressor using energy as a coercive geopolitical tool. In their discourse, recallings of previous Russian actions, such as the 2009 crisis, are present: 'When Russia halted gas supplies

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[156] U.S. Department of State. (2022, January 20). The stakes of Russian aggression for Ukraine and beyond (Speech by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/the-stakes-of-russian-aggression-for-ukraine-and-beyond/

[157] U.S. Department of State. (2022, February 7). Joint statement on the U.S.-EU Energy Council (Media Note). https://2021-2025.state.gov/joint-statement-on-the-u-s-eu-energy-council/

[158] U.S. Department of State. (2022, February 7). Secretary Antony J. Blinken with U.S. Secretary of Energy Jennifer Granholm, EU High Representative for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy and Vice President of the European Commission Josep Borrell, and European Commissioner for Energy Kadri Simson at the U.S.-EU Energy Council Ministerial (Remarks by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-antony-j-blinken-with-u-s-secretary-of-energy-jennifer-granholm-eu-high-representative-for-foreign-affairs-and-security-policy-and-vice-president-of-the-european-commission-josep-borrell/

to Europe over a dispute with Ukraine in 2009, people died from the cold'[159], said Blinken at Joint Press Availability with EU representatives — supporting the image of Russia as a killer-state.

On February 24, the anticipated Ukraine crisis happened. The CSIS report "U.S. LNG: Remapping Energy Security" examines the significant shift in global energy dynamics following the initiation of special military operation, showing how Europe expanded renewable energy initiatives, and increased imports of LNG from the United States. Despite economic strain on European industries, more costly USA LNG was still considered a better alternative to Russian supplies. U.S. natural gas exports have become crucial for European energy security (CSIS, 2023). The rise of U.S. LNG posed a direct challenge to Russia's dominance in the European gas market. Russian response included expanding its own LNG capacity and seeking new markets in Asia. However, U.S. LNG's flexible pricing and delivery model made it an attractive option for many buyers, leading to an increased competition in key markets. U.S. LNG exports helped meet rising demand in countries like China and India, reducing their reliance on Middle Eastern and Russian gas, so this fast-growing market became a new field of U.S.-Russia competition.

As a reaction to the Ukraine crisis, the USA answered with immediate sanctions[160], so did the EU. The USA also paused participation in all meetings of the Arctic Council and its subsidiary bodies[161] and suspended Russia's Permanent

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[159] U.S. Department of State. (2022, February 7). Secretary Antony J. Blinken and European Union High Representative for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy and Vice President of the European Commission Josep Borrell at a joint press availability (Remarks). https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-antony-j-blinken-and-european-union-high-representative-for-foreign-affairs-and-security-policy-and-vice-president-of-the-european-commission-josep-borrell-at-a-joint-press-availabilit/

[160] U.S. Department of State. (2022, February 25). Imposing sanctions on President Putin and three other senior Russian officials (Press Statement by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/imposing-sanctions-on-president-putin-and-three-other-senior-russian-officials/

[161] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 3). Joint statement on Arctic Council cooperation following Russia's invasion of Ukraine (Media Note). https://2021-2025.state.gov/joint-statement-on-arctic-council-cooperation-following-russias-invasion-of-ukraine/

Observer Status at the Organization of American States[162]. Since 2014 the USA provided over $2 billion assistance to Ukraine and in 2022 increased its help and as for March 2025[163], since 2022 the U.S. has provided[164] over $66.5 billion in military assistance to Ukraine, showing massive support to Russian adversary, despite money spent on anti-Russia propaganda efforts in Ukraine and European Union states. Recognition of Donetsk and Luhansk People's Republics was called by Blinken a 'blatant violation of international law'[165] — supporting anti-Russia discourse as an unreliable actor. G7 Foreign Ministers' Statement on Russia and Ukraine highlighted that 'Russia's unprovoked and unjustified massing of military forces is a challenge to global security and the international order.'[166] — showing Russia as a destabilizing actor. In response to Russia's special military operation in Ukraine, the United States adopted a multidimensional sanctions package aimed at degrading the Kremlin's 'war capacity' and punishing its political and economic elite. Sanctions were aimed at "imposing additional export controls on Russian oil and gas refining"[167], Russia's defense industry, disinformation outlets, and visa bans on Kremlin-aligned individuals. The U.S. aligns its actions with allies to project coordinated resolve, portraying Russia's aggression as a global threat that demands unified economic, technological, and diplomatic countermeasures and proclaims "commitment to ensure the Government of Russia pays a severe economic and diplomatic price" (U.S. Department of State, 2022). In March President of the European Commission Ursula

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[162] U.S. Department of State. (2022, April 21). Suspension of Russia's permanent observer status at the Organization of American States (Press Statement by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/suspension-of-russias-permanent-observer-status-at-the-organization-of-american-states/

[163] U.S. Department of State. (2022, February 14). U.S. action to strengthen Ukraine's economy (Press Statement by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/u-s-action-to-strengthen-ukraines-economy/

[164] U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Political-Military Affairs. (2025, March 12). U.S. security cooperation with Ukraine (Fact Sheet). https://www.state.gov/bureau-of-political-military-affairs/releases/2025/01/u-s-security-cooperation-with-ukraine

[165] U.S. Department of State. (2022, February 21). Kremlin decision on Eastern Ukraine (Press Statement by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/kremlin-decision-on-eastern-ukraine/

[166] U.S. Department of State. (2022, February 19). G7 Foreign Ministers' statement on Russia and Ukraine (Media Note). https://2021-2025.state.gov/g7-foreign-ministers-statement-on-russia-and-ukraine-2/

[167] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 3). *Targeting Russian elites, disinformation outlets, and defense enterprises* (Press Statement by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/targeting-russian-elites-disinformation-outlets-and-defense-enterprises/

von der Leyen stated at the meeting with Blinken: "across so many different areas - the support for Ukraine, the sanctions against Russia, the help being provided to people in distress - we're standing up together"[168]. She also underlined how close are the U.S. and the EU at responding to "Putin's reckless invasion of Ukraine" (U.S. Department of State, 2022). In the press statement 'U.S. Multilateral Leadership on the Crisis in Ukraine', Ned Price, Department Spokesperson, frames U.S. multilateral engagement on Ukraine as both a reaffirmation of American leadership and a defense of the rules-based international order[169]. Through discourse that emphasizes Russia's isolation, illegitimacy, and immorality, the U.S. promotes institutions like the United Nations as arenas for collective resistance against aggression. By mobilizing allies across multiple UN bodies and framing this crisis as an assault on global norms, the U.S. positions itself as a moral leader coordinating institutional responses to international security threats. In a March 2022 statement, Secretary of State Antony Blinken formally declared that "members of Russia's forces have committed war crimes in Ukraine," marking a significant escalation in U.S. discourse condemning Russia's military conduct. The United States, basing its assessment on public and intelligence sources, committed to pursuing accountability "using every tool available,"[170] signaling intent to coordinate with international legal mechanisms and partners to hold perpetrators responsible. Accusations of illegal cybersecurity activities were also present[171]. Led by Under Secretary Victoria Nuland and EEAS Deputy Secretary General Enrique Mora, the first U.S.-EU High-Level Dialogue on Russia, held in Washington, reinforced "exceptional unity" between the EU and U.S.

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[168] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 4). Secretary Blinken and European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen before their meeting (Remarks by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-antony-j-blinken-and-european-commission-president-ursula-von-der-leyen-before-their-meeting-2/

[169] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 5). U.S. multilateral leadership on the crisis in Ukraine (Press Statement by Ned Price, Department Spokesperson). https://2021-2025.state.gov/u-s-multilateral-leadership-on-the-crisis-in-ukraine/

[170] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 23). War crimes by Russia's forces in Ukraine (Press Statement by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/war-crimes-by-russias-forces-in-ukraine/

[171] U.S. Department of State. (2022, May 10). Attribution of Russia's malicious cyber activity against Ukraine (Press Statement by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/attribution-of-russias-malicious-cyber-activity-against-ukraine/

in condemning Russia's "unprovoked, unjustifiable, and barbaric war,"[172] and emphasized joint efforts to reduce European dependence on Russian energy. Overall, through 2022 all U.S.-EU contact, cooperation and talks contained mentioning of Russia as an immoral aggressor and calls for eliminating European energy dependence on Russian supplies.

Bilateral talks with EU member states also supported the narrative of Russian energy supplies being used as a weapon and promoted the idea of the need to get rid of the 'dependency' and deprive Russia of the ability to use energy as a 'weapon'. For example, talks with Austria[173] (including energy security in light of Russian 'aggression'), with Estonia[174], when during their joint press availability in Tallinn Antony Blinken and Estonian Prime Minister Kaja Kallas emphasized unity in responding to Ukrainian crisis 2022 and advancing energy security. Instruments discussed included military support to Ukraine, enhanced U.S. troop presence in the Baltics, sanctions against Russia, and efforts to diversify global energy supplies. Prime Minister Kallas, drawing on Estonia's history under Soviet occupation, called for full isolation of Russia, and reinforced energy sanctions. Blinken-Kallas consensus was clear: Russian supplies are a danger that has to be dealt with by diversification of supplies and diverging from Russia. Slovenia - U.S. Strategic Dialogue[175] also emphasized energy security as one of three main pillars, especially under the light of Russia-Ukraine conflict. In their March 2022 joint statement, the United States and Croatia reaffirmed their alignment on energy security, climate action, and regional

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[172] European External Action Service & U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 30). EU/US: Joint press release by the EEAS and U.S. Department of State on the first high-level dialogue on Russia. https://www.eeas.europa.eu/eeas/euus-joint-press-release-eeas-and-us-department-state-first-high-level-dialogue-russia_en

[173] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 7). Joint statement on the strategic dialogue between the United States and Austria (Media Note). https://2021-2025.state.gov/joint-statement-on-the-strategic-dialogue-between-the-united-states-and-austria/

[174] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 8). Secretary Antony J. Blinken and Estonian Prime Minister Kaja Kallas at a joint press availability (Remarks). https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-antony-j-blinken-and-estonian-prime-minister-kaja-kallas-at-a-joint-press-availability/

[175] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 14). Slovenia – U.S. Strategic Dialogue joint statement (Media Note). https://2021-2025.state.gov/slovenia-u-s-strategic-dialogue-joint-statement/

cooperation, showcasing energy diversification as both a geopolitical and environmental strategy. With regard to Croatia[176], the U.S. praised Croatia's "leadership on energy diversification through the opening of the floating liquefied natural gas terminal off Krk island" and supported its role in broader regional initiatives like the Southern Connector to Bosnia and Herzegovina. The partnership was further institutionalized through their engagement with the Partnership for Transatlantic Energy and Climate Cooperation (P-TECC), highlighting the integration of energy and climate diplomacy in U.S. regional strategy.

In **2022** the main emphasis of U.S. public statements regarding energy and energy security was put on Russia and European affairs, especially regarding the Ukraine crisis. But energy relations with other regions continued, such as Egypt and Thailand[177], Bahrain[178], Norway and UK[179], Pakistan[180], Azerbaijan[181] and others. Actions tackling climate change also continued, such as "Implementation Plus: Global Climate Action in 2022"[182] — speech of John Kerry, Special Presidential Envoy for Climate, in Cairo in February 2022, which positioned the USA as a global climate change driver and linked climate change to security, economic prosperity, public health, and historical justice, invoking religious and civilizational narratives to ground climate stewardship in universal values. United States Long-Term Strategy under the

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[176] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 17). U.S.-Croatia joint statement (Media Note). https://2021-2025.state.gov/u-s-croatia-joint-statement/

[177] U.S. Department of State. (2022, February 11). Bureau of Energy Resources Senior Bureau Official Kamian's travel to Egypt and Thailand (Media Note). https://2021-2025.state.gov/bureau-of-energy-resources-senior-bureau-official-kamians-travel-to-egypt-and-thailand/

[178] U.S. Department of State. (2022, March 7). Joint statement of the second U.S.-Bahrain Strategic Dialogue (Media Note). https://2021-2025.state.gov/joint-statement-of-the-second-u-s-bahrain-strategic-dialogue/

[179] U.S. Department of State. (2022, May 4). Special Presidential Envoy for Climate Kerry's travel to Norway and the United Kingdom (Media Note). https://2021-2025.state.gov/special-presidential-envoy-for-climate-kerrys-travel-to-norway-and-the-united-kingdom/

[180] U.S. Department of State. (2022, May 6). Secretary Blinken's call with Pakistani Foreign Minister Bhutto Zardari (Readout). https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-blinkens-call-with-pakistani-foreign-minister-bhutto-zardari/

[181] U.S. Department of State. (2022, May 11). Secretary Blinken's call with Azerbaijani President Aliyev (Readout). https://2021-2025.state.gov/secretary-blinkens-call-with-azerbaijani-president-aliyev-3/

[182] U.S. Department of State. (2022, February 21). Special Presidential Envoy for Climate John Kerry "Implementation Plus: Global Climate Action in 2022" (Remarks by John Kerry, Special Presidential Envoy for Climate). https://2021-2025.state.gov/special-presidential-envoy-for-climate-john-kerry-implementation-plus-global-climate-action-in-2022/

Paris Agreement that sets aim to achieve a net-zero economy by 2050, and participation in the Earth Day 2022[183] as well as consensus at the UN Environment Assembly to create a negotiating process to end plastic pollution — these actions support the general commitment of the U.S. to tackle climate change and support a better environment for a sustainable future. However, in 2022 the USA was still a second state after China contributing to CO2 emissions and thus greenhouse effect, that it called to deal with (Paddison & Choi, 2024).

In **2023-2024** the United States aggressively leveraged its status as a major gas exporter to influence world markets. In 2023 80% of Germany LNG imports came from the U.S.[184] European countries 'benefit' from the decreasing dependence on Russian imports in context of crisis and instability, while Asian allies benefit from LNG as they try to decrease coal consumption, highlighting the success and global reach of U.S. gas diplomacy — in fact, it is the U.S. that benefits the most. The Biden administration publicly committed to helping Europe diversify away from Russian gas, including targets set with EU partners (e.g. aiming for ~50 bcm/yr of U.S. LNG to Europe by 2030)[185]. However, the U.S. also balanced this with environmental concerns. In January 2024 the Department of Energy "paused" approval of new LNG export projects to conduct a climate review. President Biden stressed that this pause would allow study of emissions impacts and "sees the climate crisis for what it is: the existential threat of our time"[186].

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[183] U.S. Department of State. (2022, April 22). Earth Day 2022 (Press Statement by Antony J. Blinken, Secretary of State). https://2021-2025.state.gov/earth-day-2022/

[184] U.S. Energy Information Administration. (2024, February 29). The United States remained the largest liquefied natural gas supplier to Europe in 2023. https://www.eia.gov/todayinenergy/detail.php?id=61483

[185] Center for Strategic and International Studies. (2024, February 7). Geopolitical significance of U.S. LNG. https://www.csis.org/analysis/geopolitical-significance-us-lng#:~:text=The%20Biden%20administration%20pledged%20in,annum.%E2%80%9D%20The%20market%20delivered.

[186] Lashof, D. (2024, July 30). Tracking progress: Climate action under the Biden administration. World Resources Institute. https://www.wri.org/insights/biden-administration-tracking-climate-action-progress#:~:text=Biden%20emphasized%20that%20%E2%80%9C%5Bt%5D,carbon%20dioxide%20into%20the%20atmosphere.

A central pillar of U.S. strategy was to tighten sanctions on Russia's oil and gas sector. In late 2024, the State Department announced "fresh sanctions" on entities tied to the Nord Stream 2 pipeline, re-designating numerous companies involved in construction and operation[187]. Similarly, in November 2024 the U.S. imposed sanctions on dozens of firms and vessels connected to Russia's Arctic LNG 2 project[188]. By targeting the contractors, carriers and insurers supporting that plant, Washington sought to block Russian plans to expand LNG exports in the future. These actions complemented existing measures: since early 2022 the U.S. had applied price-cap regimes on Russian oil and banned services for Soviet-era pipelines. The 2023-24 round of sanctions thus deepened the squeeze on Moscow's hydrocarbon revenues. In Congressional and executive statements, U.S. policymakers underscored that sanctions would "ratchet up the risk" of doing business in Russia's oil industry[189], ensuring that Western capital and technology could not easily reinvigorate Russian fields.

The Biden administration consistently portrayed itself as combining energy security with environmental responsibility. For example, at COP28 in Dubai U.S. officials unveiled stringent methane rules for the oil and gas sector. Vice President Harris cited these measures to declare that the United States had restored the United States as a global leader in the fight against climate change. Similarly, in April 2023 President Biden convened the Major Economies Forum on Energy and Climate and announced major finance commitments for developing countries. He pledged an extra $1 billion to the Green Climate Fund (doubling the U.S. share) and proposed $0.5

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[187] U.S. Department of State. (2024, December 18). Re-imposing sanctions on certain entities involved in Nord Stream 2 (Fact Sheet). https://2021-2025.state.gov/re-imposing-sanctions-on-certain-entities-involved-in-nord-stream-2/

[188] Reuters. (2024, November 1). LNG entities under US sanctions to curb Russia's Arctic LNG 2 project. https://www.reuters.com/markets/commodities/lng-entities-under-us-sanctions-curb-russias-arctic-lng-2-project-2024-08-26/

[189] U.S. Department of the Treasury. (2025, January 10). Treasury intensifies sanctions against Russia by targeting Russia's oil production and exports. https://home.treasury.gov/news/press-releases/jy2777#:~:text=%E2%80%9CThe%20United%20States%20is%20taking,%E2%80%9D

billion for Brazil's Amazon Fund to curb deforestation[190]. June 2023 U.S.-India Joint Statement launched a "Climate and Clean Energy Agenda 2030 Partnership,"[191] highlighting joint work on renewables, hydrogen and energy storage. The U.S. energy policy in 2023-24 was explicitly justified in climate terms. Energy discussions at international meetings routinely emphasized net-zero goals. By framing energy exports, sanctions and domestic regulations as part of a climate-friendly "win-win" narrative, U.S. leaders sought to recast the American role in global energy from "fossil power" to "clean-power facilitator".

Beyond Europe, the U.S. extended its energy influence through targeted outreach in Asia, Africa and the Americas. In Asia, the administration deepened collaboration with key buyers and partners. At the Summit for a New Global Financing Pact in March 2023, the U.S. secured backing from Japan and South Korea to increase renewable energy finance in Asia. Official visits underscored this: for example, in June 2023 President Biden and Prime Minister Modi announced a broad technology and climate partnership. They launched joint initiatives on green hydrogen, offshore wind, and critical minerals under a newly established U.S.-India "Strategic Clean Energy Partnership"[192]. The U.S. also worked through regional forums: the Indo-Pacific Strategy released in January 2025 (reflecting 2024 actions) explicitly made climate and clean energy a cornerstone of alliances with Japan and Australia[193]. In practice this meant U.S. agencies and development finance groups supported renewable projects and grid modernization across Asia. For instance, U.S. trade and development agencies provided loans and grants for solar and LNG

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[190] CNBC. (2023, April 20). Biden pledges $500 million to fight Amazon deforestation, but Congress must approve. https://www.cnbc.com/2023/04/20/biden-pledges-500-million-to-fight-amazon-deforestation.html

[191] U.S. Department of Energy. (2023, July). *U.S.-India Strategic Clean Energy Partnership: Sustainable Growth Pillar*. https://www.energy.gov/sites/default/files/2023-07/USISCEP-SustainableGrowth.pdf

[192] The White House. (2023, June 22). Joint statement from the United States and India. https://bidenwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefing-room/statements-releases/2023/06/22/joint-statement-from-the-united-states-and-india/#:~:text=17,leaders%20welcomed%20joint%20efforts%20to

[193] The White House. (2025, January 10). The United States' enduring commitment to the Indo-Pacific region. https://bidenwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefing-room/statements-releases/2025/01/10/the-united-states-enduring-commitment-to-the-indo-pacific-region/

infrastructure in countries like Vietnam and the Philippines, leveraging American capital for energy security objectives. In Africa, U.S. diplomatic engagement on energy was intensified by the 2022 U.S.-Africa Leaders Summit commitments. In 2023 the White House reported 17 senior delegations to 26 African countries, often focusing on energy and climate issues[194]. Overall, though Europe remained the top destination for U.S. gas, the Asia-Africa-Latin engagements ensured U.S. influence extended worldwide through project financing, technology partnerships and trade.

In 2023-24 a common theme was the contrast between 'democratic' versus 'autocratic' energy. The U.S. repeatedly characterized Russia as an unreliable supplier that weaponizes its energy. Biden and his spokespeople highlighted energy cooperation with democracies as part of a broader ideological struggle. In meetings with world leaders the U.S. often emphasized that fighting climate change and upholding democracy were twin priorities. For instance, in February 2023 Biden told Brazil's President Lula that the two countries were united by the need to maintain democracy, reach Russia-Ukraine peace while also tackling the climate crisis[195]. The implication was clear: U.S. energy policy served not only market goals but also a values-based agenda. In sum, U.S. rhetoric blended traditional security language with climate and democracy narratives. The administration labeled Russian energy 'weaponization' as illegitimate and depicted alternatives (U.S. gas, renewables finance). This messaging was intended to rally partner countries around U.S. objectives: by framing energy supply as a matter of collective security and shared values, American leaders sought to keep allies aligned even as they pushed for ambitious emissions reductions.

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[194] The White House. (2023, December 13). Fact sheet: Accelerating the U.S.–Africa partnership after the 2022 U.S.-Africa Leaders Summit. https://bidenwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefing-room/statements-releases/2023/12/13/fact-sheet-accelerating-the-u-s-africa-partnership-after-the-2022-u-s-africa-leaders-summit/

[195] The White House. (2023, February 10). Joint statement following the meeting between President Biden and President Lula. https://bidenwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefing-room/statements-releases/2023/02/10/joint-statement-following-the-meeting-between-president-biden-and-president-lula/

3.5 Conclusion: The U.S. Influence on Global Energy Markets

Now it is important to assess the influence of various U.S. foreign policy instruments on the transformation of global energy markets. These instruments can be broadly categorized into sanctions, trade agreements, diplomacy, military power and climate policies. Based on previously conducted analysis it is possible to categorize the actions into categories and to assign weights to each instrument based on its relative influence on energy dynamics; these weights with examples are reflected in Table 1. The visualization of the impact of these instruments is present in a radar chart, figure 1, which allows to clearly see which tools have been more significant.

- **Sanctions (2.5)**: Sanctions have been a significant tool in reshaping global energy markets, particularly by restricting access to key energy players like Russia, Iran, and Venezuela — it provoked redirection of global energy flows, created opportunities for alternative suppliers, and reduced the dominance of certain energy-producing nations.
- **Trade (2)**: Trade agreements, particularly LNG exports, have positioned the U.S. as a major energy exporter, transforming global energy flows and creating opportunities for energy diversification. However, trade is often broader in scope and involves longer-term strategies, which is why it is moderately influential in transforming energy markets.
- **Diplomacy (2.5)**: Energy diplomacy has been central to the U.S.'s efforts to diversify global energy sources and ensure long-term energy security. Diplomatic initiatives like the U.S.-EU Energy Task Force have been crucial in promoting energy diversification, alternative sources of energy, and international cooperation on energy security, making it a highly impactful tool in the transformation of global energy markets.
- **Military Power (1)**: While military power has historically been used to secure energy supply routes and maintain stability in key energy-producing regions, its

role in shaping global energy markets has been reduced in recent years. The global energy landscape has shifted more toward economic and diplomatic tools, and military power now plays a secondary role in influencing energy market dynamics, while its past influence is still present in U.S. presence in the Middle East. Even the fact of the U.S. financial and intelligence involvement in the Ukraine crisis supports its dominant role in EU markets, which is also an indirect military effect.

- **Climate Policies (1.5)**: Climate policies play a significant role in shaping the global energy transition, encouraging the adoption of renewable energy and reducing reliance on fossil fuels. Through promotion of renewable energy technologies, as well as unconventional energy, the U.S. has indirectly influenced global energy markets, driving long-term shifts in energy production and consumption.

Table 1. U.S. Foreign Policy Instruments in the Transformation of Global Energy Markets (2008–2024)

U.S. Instruments	**Weight (1 to 3)**	**Examples**	**Consequences**
Sanctions	2.5	Sanctions on Russia, Iran, Venezuela, Syria, Nord Stream 2, TurkStream, Arctic LNG 2	Weakened adversaries' energy sectors, redirected global energy flows, reduced reliance on certain suppliers

Trade	2	U.S. LNG exports to Europe, support of energy infrastructure projects (Krk island), bilateral LNG agreements	Enhanced U.S. role as a leading energy exporter, promoted energy diversification globally
Diplomacy	2.5	U.S.-EU Energy Task Force (2022), energy diversification agreements with Saudi Arabia and Qatar, Three Seas Initiative summits, U.S.-EU Energy Council, Asia EDGE Initiative	Strengthened global energy security on basis of US leadership facilitated long-term diversification of energy sources, reduced geopolitical risks in energy supply chains
Military Power	1	U.S. military presence in the Middle East	Ensured stable energy routes globally, but less impactful in recent years on shaping long-term energy market transformation.
Climate Policies	1.5	Rejoining the Paris Agreement (2021), promoting renewable	Fostered global transition to renewable energy, influenced long-term shifts in energy production, reduced reliance on

		energy, and electric vehicles	fossil fuels, and set global sustainability standards.

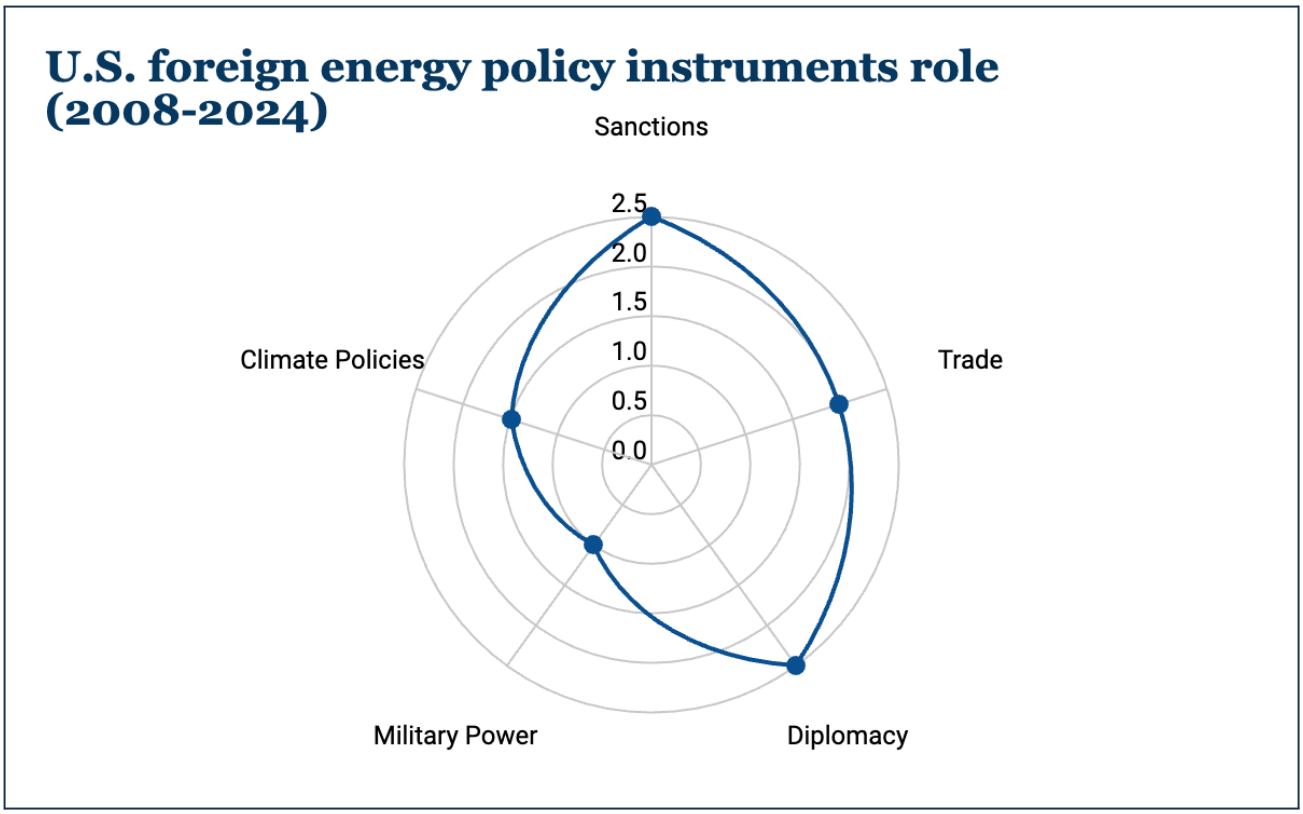

Figure 1. Radar chart of U.S. foreign policy instruments role

CHAPTER 4: ANALYSIS OF IMPLICATIONS OF TRANSFORMED ENERGY MARKETS FOR RUSSIA AND RUSSIA-EU RELATIONS

4.1 The Transformation of Russia-EU Energy Relations

As mentioned in previous chapters, the EU and Russia have had strong economic ties, with mutual desire to economically integrate since the 1990s. Crises of 2006 and 2009 (with Russia cutting off gas supplies), 2008 (with concerns over Georgia), and Ukraine conflicts of 2014 and 2022 were significant events in decreasing trust between EU and Russia. Crises of 2006 and 2009, despite raising critical concerns, did not provoke significant reduction of cooperation and securitization of Russia. But the 2014 Crimean crisis was followed by open accusations and real decisions on reduction of Russian supplies as dangerous ones that could be used as a weapon. The EU launched an energy security strategy to diversify supplies (investing in LNG terminals, new pipelines, and renewable gas; promoting new trade partnerships; plans on decreasing fossil fuels dependence). However, pipelines from Russia continued to supply more than 40% of EU gas needs into 2021 (Council of the European Union, 2025). Despite accusations, real reductions of Russian supplies began after the 2022 crisis, supported by initiatives such as the REPowerEU plan and increased supplies from the USA and Norway (ibid.): in 2024 overall Russian gas (pipeline and LNG) accounted for only around 19% of EU supply (compared with 33% from Norway and 16.5% from the U.S.). In sum, there was a shift from ‘pre-2014 dependence’ through a modest ‘diversification’ stage, to a rapid ‘post-2022 decoupling’ driven by Russia-Ukraine instability. The U.S. actively lobbied the EU to reduce Russian imports and supported increasing securitizing discourse at times it appeared in the EU — it coincided with the USA’s opportunity to promote its supplies of LNG (e.g. Trump’s accusations of Nord Stream being a tool of coercion that undermines European security). After 2022 the Biden administration and EU formed a “Task Force on Energy Security” and U.S. LNG exports to Europe

surged (from ~22 bcm in 2021 to ~56 bcm in 2022)[196]. U.S. LNG thus became the largest source of imported LNG: in 2023 roughly 48% of EU LNG imports came from the U.S (EIA, 2024). At the same time, the U.S. used hard power (sanctions on Russian pipeline projects) and soft diplomacy (energy guarantees and joint declarations) to encourage EU diversification. Price comparisons are also important: U.S. LNG is typically priced at Henry Hub plus liquefaction / shipment costs, which historically has been higher than Russia's oil-indexed pipeline price. Russia's energy minister noted in 2018 that the U.S. LNG costs "30–40% higher" than Russian pipeline gas.[197] In fact, after 2022 shifts, Russian LNG supplies to the EU did not diminish, but increased. Moreover, their price increased sharply with the EU in 2024 paying 274% more for Russian LNG, coming mostly from the Arctic, than in 2021[198]. These actions may seem economically 'irrational', but they show a shift from prioritising interdependence and economically beneficial trade to prioritization of political motives. The EU is ready to sacrifice economic gains and pay more for Norwegian, American and even the same Russian gas (that still comes but not via previous pipeline routes). These modern developments support constructivist arguments — securitization drives actions even if they are 'irrational' from the point of view of classical IR theories.

Moreover, the hybrid warfare that began in the U.S.-Russia relations in 2022 is important. It includes disinformation campaigns, economic sanctions, especially secondary sanctions from the USA — to make other states fear of being friendly to Russia. The United States is also the founding and leading state of NATO, an organisation created against Soviet communist threat and that continues to work and expand, being a major point of confrontation between Russia and Western forces, with

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[196] The White House. (2023, April 3). Joint statement on U.S.-EU Task Force on Energy Security. https://bidenwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefing-room/statements-releases/2023/04/03/joint-statement-on-u-s-eu-task-force-on-energy-security/

[197] Temizer, M. (2018, May 27). U.S. LNG price up to 40% higher than Russian gas: Novak. Anadolu Agency. https://www.aa.com.tr/en/energy/energy-diplomacy/us-lng-price-up-to-40-higher-than-russian-gas-novak/20225

[198] High North News. (2025, February 27). EU paid near 300% more for Russian LNG in 2024 compared to early 2021. https://www.highnorthnews.com/en/eu-paid-near-300-more-russian-lng-2024-compared-early-2021

23 out of 27 European Union states being members of both organisations. All of these developments in U.S. foreign policy tools have impacted the European Union.

Deep economic ties allow the U.S. to leverage it in relations with the EU and promote influence. The Transatlantic Economy 2023 report[199] underscores the profound and enduring economic interdependence between the United States and Europe, characterizing it as the most deeply integrated commercial partnership globally. Despite global shocks (from COVID-19 pandemic and Russia's special military operation in Ukraine to inflationary pressures and energy disruptions), the $7.1 trillion transatlantic economy has shown remarkable resilience. It remains the largest and wealthiest market in the world, accounting for half of total global personal consumption and employing 16 million workers in onshored jobs across both regions. This interconnectedness of economies continues to serve as a vital foundation for the prosperity, competitiveness, and strategic alignment of both sides of the Atlantic.

In an attempt to portray Russia as an untrustworthy partner and defend the move to alternative energy sources, the U.S. supported the EU in anti-Russian rhetoric and helped to enact policies that not only guarantee energy security but also complement larger Western strategic objectives. Furthermore, the EU's energy alliances needed to be reevaluated in light of its commitment to green energy. By supporting laws and technology that encourage renewable energy, the United States has established itself as a major actor in the energy transition. Nowadays there are continuing dual challenges of energy security and climate change that have to be carefully dealt with by the EU.

In short, the U.S. policy was a significant factor, but not the only one, in Europe's energy shift. EU member states also followed their own security calculus:

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[199] Hamilton, D. S., & Quinlan, J. P. (2023). The Transatlantic Economy 2023: Annual Survey of Jobs, Trade and Investment between the United States and Europe. Foreign Policy Institute, Johns Hopkins University SAIS / Transatlantic Leadership Network. https://www.transatlanticrelations.org/

some firms openly proposed resuming limited Russian imports if peace returns[200]. The EU elite is generally anti-Russian, despite opinions of states that do not support 'energy divorce' with Russia, most officials stand for it. For instance, Josep Borrell, the High Representative of the Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy and Vice-President of the European Commission, has a very anti-Russian position, and he is co-chairing the U.S.-EU Energy Council with the U.S. Secretary of State and relevant EU energy officials, so his opinion and views are linked to the overall EU direction regarding relations to Russia and energy supplies. When the EU put sanctions on the Russian energy sector in March 2022, Borrell proclaimed that the aim was to "make it impossible for Russia to upgrade its oil refineries"[201] (Council of the European Union, 2022). He also said that Russia is "an economic dwarf — it's like a gas station whose owner has an atomic bomb" (Pérez and Doncel, 2023). This discourse is present in various EU documents and official statements. U.S. narratives and propaganda helped to securitize EU perceptions of Russia, but this influence was not the only and primary cause of EU policy changes. Internal concerns are stronger. The EU has its own strong anti-Russian position with securitizing discourse steadily increasing since 2006, but reaching its peak followed by real actions in 2022. Thoughtful diversification and partnership strategies on all sides — combined with realistic pricing and recognition of climate trends — will shape the long-term energy and geopolitical landscape.

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[200] Hernandez, A., Alkousaa, R., & Rashad, M. (2025, April 14). Back to Russian gas? Trump-wary EU has energy security dilemma. Reuters. https://www.reuters.com/business/energy/back-russian-gas-trump-wary-eu-has-energy-security-dilemma-2025-04-14/

[201] Council of the European Union (2022, February 25). Russia's military aggression against Ukraine: EU imposes sanctions against President Putin and Foreign Minister Lavrov and adopts wide ranging individual and economic sanctions [Press release] https://www.consilium.europa.eu/en/press/press-releases/2022/02/25/russia-s-military-aggression-against-ukraine-eu-imposes-sanctions-against-president-putin-and-foreign-minister-lavrov-and-adopts-wide-ranging-individual-and-economic-sanctions/

4.2 Geopolitical and Economic Consequences: Russia's Energy Pivot to Asia

Russia's economy remains heavily reliant on oil and gas revenues. Fossil fuels accounted for about 16.5% of GDP in 2023 (1.5% less than in 2022)[202]. Western sanctions since 2014 have targeted this sector. Sanctions on LNG projects forced Novatek to declare force majeure on its Arctic LNG-2 output[203], delaying production. The collapse of exports to Europe also hurt Russia. In 2023 Europe accounted for only ~5%[204] of Russian crude exports (down from ~40% pre-2022) and even less of its gas. The Nord Stream sabotage and EU embargoes meant Russian pipeline gas revenue evaporated. In response, Russia has pivoted eastwards — the so-called 'Pivot to Asia'. The Power of Siberia pipeline to China (started in 2019, eventual capacity ~38 bcm)[205] carries significant volumes and more projects are planned (Power of Siberia 2 to Mongolia / China). Major LNG capacity is also being directed to Asia. The Arctic LNG-2 project (led by Novatek) is designed for 19.8 millions of tonnes per year (Mt/year)[206] and has secured long-term deals with Chinese and Indian buyers. For example, Novatek signed contracts to supply China's ENN Gas (~0.6 Mt/year)[207] in 2022 and Zhejiang Energy (~1.0 Mt/yr)[208] in 2021, and an MoU with India's Deepak Fertilisers[209] (volume undisclosed). In oil, Russia has re-allocated tankers to China and India: by January 2024, Russia was redirecting much of its crude formerly sold to Europe to Asian markets. However, this pivot faces structural obstacles. Asian markets are farther and already served by Qatar / Australia LNG, so Russia must

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[202] Kommersant. (2024, April 5). Dolya neftegazovogo sektora v VVP RF v 2023 godu snizilas' do 16.5% [Share of the oil and gas sector in Russia's GDP fell to 16.5% in 2023]. https://www.kommersant.ru/doc/6632852

[203] Interfax. (2023, December 21). NOVATEK obyavil fors-mazhor po proektu "Arktik SPG 2" iz-za sanktsiy SShA [NOVATEK declared force majeure on Arctic LNG 2 project due to U.S. sanctions]. https://www.interfax.ru/business/937445

[204] Parlamentskaya Gazeta. (2023, December 27). Novak: Eksport nefti v Evropu sostavit ne bolee 4–5% ot obshchego obema [Novak: Oil exports to Europe will account for no more than 4–5% of the total volume]. https://www.pnp.ru/economics/novak-eksport-nefti-v-evropu-sostavit-ne-bolee-4-5-ot-obshhego-obema.html

[205] Gazprom. (n.d.). Power of Siberia. https://www.gazprom.com/projects/power-of-siberia/

[206] Arctic SPG. (n.d.). O proekte [About the project]. https://arcticspg.ru/

[207] NOVATEK. (2022, January 11). NOVATEK and ENN Natural Gas sign sales and purchase agreement on long-term LNG supply. https://www.novatek.ru/en/press/releases/index.php?id_4=4826

[208] NOVATEK. (2021, June 2). NOVATEK and Zhejiang Energy sign Heads of Agreement on LNG supply. https://www.novatek.ru/en/press/releases/index.php?id_4=4493

[209] NOVATEK. (2023, February 6). NOVATEK and Deepak Fertilisers sign MoU on LNG and low-carbon ammonia. https://www.novatek.ru/en/press/releases/index.php?id_4=5518&_=1706000300140&from_4=3

compete on price and reliability. The USA is a competitor on the Asian market which already threatens Australian dominance on this market — which is main LNG supplier of Japan and South Korea. In 2022, Japan was the largest buyer of Australian LNG, accounting for about 40% of total sales, followed by China, South Korea, and Taiwan[210]. Meg O'Neill, chief executive of Woodside Energy (Australian company), claimed that Australia "loses on every front"[211] to the US — the reason is high taxes and costs of labour.

However, the financial part is important here: Chinese contracts reportedly come with steep discounts, squeezing Russian margins. Russia forecasted that China will pay much lower prices: about $271–297 per 1,000 cubic meters vs ~$480 per 1,000 cubic meters charged to Europe in 2023[212]. Infrastructure remains limited: no major pipeline reaches India, and Russia's pipelines to China cannot be built overnight. Domestically, Russia faces a shrinking Euro-demand for fuel while being increasingly dependent on a few Asian customers. In sum, while the Eastward pivot is real, it entails reinvestment and exposes Russia to new vulnerabilities.

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[210] Center on Global Energy Policy. (2023, August 10). Q&A: Potential supply disruptions from industrial action at Australia's LNG plants. Columbia University. https://www.energypolicy.columbia.edu/qa-potential-supply-disruptions-from-industrial-action-at-australias-lng-plants/

[211] Wood, J. (2025, February 6). Australia 'losing on every front' to Donald Trump's US, warns Woodside chief. Financial Times. https://www.ft.com/content/a471c4bd-0d6b-4dfb-95b1-bbda8d1227b0

[212] Ajmera, R. (2023, September 8). Russia will sell natural gas to China at almost a 50% discount compared to European buyers. Business Insider. https://markets.businessinsider.com/news/commodities/russia-china-energy-trade-discount-turkey-europe-buyers-ukraine-beijing-2023-9

4.3 Future Implications and Policy Recommendations

Recommendations for Russia

Understanding U.S. foreign policy instruments is crucial in navigating the evolving global energy landscape. Knowing that the USA primarily acts through sanctions and diplomacy, Russia should recognize the importance of energy diplomacy and actively seek new multilateral agreements to secure long-term energy security. Returning to the European market at pre-2022 levels now seems unlikely without a major political shift. European leaders have pledged to phase out Russian energy by 2027[213], and even in the event of peace normalization is not very likely (perhaps on the order of 20–30% of former volumes). Therefore, Russia should accelerate economic diversification beyond hydrocarbons. In the near term it can deepen ties in Asia: completing Power of Siberia 2, expanding LNG capacity (e.g. Arctic LNG expansion), and forging more gas-for-industry deals with China / India. Simultaneously, Russia could benefit by developing non-gas sectors at home (e.g. petrochemicals, renewables) as well as other sectors of the economy in order to reduce budget dependence, though these initiatives are not new, in practical terms the budget is still dependent on material resources revenue. Transparency on pricing and adherence to contracts will help build trust with new partners, which is already shown by Chinese deals. By understanding and adapting to these U.S. strategies, Russia can better anticipate challenges and position itself for greater energy security in a shifting geopolitical environment.

End of shale revolution?

While the U.S. shale revolution and LNG exports reshaped global energy markets, several challenges are faced by the USA. Shale wells have high initial production rates but decline rapidly, requiring continuous drilling to maintain output.

[213] European Commission. (2025, May 6). EU to fully end its dependency on Russian energy [Press release]. https://ec.europa.eu/commission/presscorner/detail/en/ip_25_1131

The physical limits of shale formations will eventually constrain production, raising questions about the long-term sustainability of the shale boom. Moreover, the U.S. Department of Energy (2024) highlighted potential domestic implications of increasing LNG exports. Higher LNG exports could lead to increased domestic natural gas prices, which may then affect electricity prices and manufacturing costs. This underscores the need for careful consideration of the balance between export growth and domestic energy affordability: "DOE analysis exposes a triple-cost increase to U.S. consumers from increasing LNG exports – the increasing domestic price of the natural gas itself, increases in electricity prices (natural gas being a key input in many U.S. power markets), and the increased costs for consumers from the pass-through of higher costs to U.S. manufacturers."[214]. Therefore, the long-term U.S. influence on the global LNG market and availability to offer favorable conditions for exports of high amounts of energy products is questioned. Overall, the shale boom and the development of U.S. LNG exports totally reoriented the landscape of world energy. By becoming the world's leading producer of oil and natural gas, the U.S. not only increased its energy security but also substantially increased its geopolitical influence. U.S. LNG became a vital tool for diversifying world energy supplies and reducing Europe's dependence on Russian gas. But the long-term sustainability of the shale boom is not guaranteed. The coming decade will show whether the U.S. can sustain its leadership or if a more multipolar energy regime will emerge.

The global gas market is entering a longer transition. As major economies decarbonize, overall natural gas demand growth will slow or even decline by mid-century[215]. To keep the U.S. LNG competitive, producers should mitigate environmental concerns: invest in methane leak reduction and carbon capture at

[214] U.S. Department of Energy. (2024, December 17). U.S. Department of Energy completes LNG study update, announces 60-day comment period. https://www.energy.gov/articles/us-department-energy-completes-lng-study-update-announces-60-day-comment-period

[215] International Energy Agency. (2021, July 5). Natural gas demand growth set to slow in coming years, but strong policy actions still needed to bring it on track for net-zero emissions [Press release]. https://www.iea.org/news/natural-gas-demand-growth-set-to-slow-in-coming-years-but-strong-policy-actions-still-needed-to-bring-it-on-track-for-net-zero-emissions

liquefaction facilities. Flexible contracts (shorter duration, destination clauses) will make U.S. LNG more attractive to buyers wary of stranded assets. U.S. energy diplomacy must also adapt: emphasize gas as a bridging fuel in the clean-energy transition and package LNG exports with cooperation on renewables and energy efficiency. For example, the U.S. could expand incentives (loan guarantees or grants) for countries to modernize their gas infrastructure or build regasification terminals in exchange for LNG commitments. Diplomatically, the U.S. should work through forums like the U.S.-EU Energy Council to align gas exports with climate goals (e.g. by supporting green-hydrogen hubs in Europe that complement LNG use).

From petrodollar to gas-dollar?

Existing U.S. policy signals a move to replicate the petrodollar system in the LNG sector — so-called "gas-dollar" strategy. By promoting dollar-denominated sales contracts for LNG and constructing export facilities, the U.S. aims to secure its position in global gas markets. Much like the petrodollar system, the gas-dollar strategy aims to promote the dominance of U.S. natural gas in global trade and ensure that these transactions are conducted primarily in U.S. dollars. This approach is not only driven by economic motives but also reflects broader geopolitical objectives. The gas-dollar strategy is part of a wider effort by the U.S. to secure market share in the global LNG trade and reduce the influence of rival energy powers, particularly Russia. Unlike traditional long-term contracts used by Russia and Qatar, U.S. LNG contracts often offer more flexibility in pricing and delivery schedules, making them attractive to buyers in Europe and Asia. For instance, U.S. LNG is usually priced based on the Henry Hub natural gas benchmark, offering an alternative to the oil-linked pricing models commonly used by other suppliers. This pricing structure can be advantageous for buyers seeking to diversify their price exposure (MEI, 2024). However, the global energy landscape has changed significantly since the 1970s. Rising nations like China and India increasingly demand energy trade in home

currencies. China has been actively promoting the use of its currency, the yuan, in international energy transactions, aiming to challenge the dominance of the U.S. dollar in the global energy market. Russia pursues a creation and stabilisation of a multipolar international order, particularly pursuing multipolar energy policy, also promoting the use of home currencies in transactions with China, India, and other allies. In October 2023, the China National Petroleum Corporation (CNPC) completed a transaction settling 1 million barrels of crude oil using digital yuan, marking a significant step in yuan-based energy trade (Global Times, 2023). Moreover, Russia's focus on real assets — such as physical infrastructure and long-term supply agreements — contrasts with the U.S.'s more market-oriented approach. The EU's ambitious climate goals aim to phase out fossil fuels, including natural gas, by 2050, reducing the potential market for the U.S. LNG[216]. This transition is expected to reduce the potential market for U.S. LNG exports to Europe. Additionally, the EU is drafting its first 2040 climate target, aiming for a 90% reduction in net greenhouse gas emissions by that date compared to 1990 levels. Recommendations for his plan included an 80% reduction in fossil fuel use for energy by 2040[217], further diminishing the role of natural gas in the EU's energy mix — a challenge for Russia as well, as supplies of Russian gas did not stop and still bring revenue, either through shadow fleet, re-sales from India, LNG or TurkStream. For Russia, the "gas-dollar" represents both a challenge and an opportunity to promote a more diversified and multipolar energy system.

[216]European Commission. (n.d.). The European Green Deal. https://commission.europa.eu/strategy-and-policy/priorities-2019-2024/european-green-deal_en

[217] European Commission. (2024, February 6). Commission presents recommendation for 2040 emissions reduction target to set the path to climate neutrality in 2050 [Press release]. https://ec.europa.eu/commission/presscorner/detail/en/ip_24_588

CONCLUSION

This study investigated the United States' role in reshaping global energy markets between 2008 and 2024, with specific emphasis on its influence on Russia and Russia-EU energy relations. In exploring U.S. foreign policy instruments — sanctions, trade agreements, diplomacy, military power and climate policies — the research found how the USA has leveraged its energy resources to drive geopolitical and economic changes on the global stage. The research question, which sought to assess how the U.S. influenced global energy markets and the EU-Russia energy relationship, was addressed by examining the evolution of U.S. actions over several critical periods between 2008 and 2024. U.S. energy policy radically shifted, especially with the shale revolution that transformed the world energy balance by turning the U.S. from an energy importer into a key energy exporter. This shift played a pivotal role in reconfiguring the energy supply lines, particularly in Europe, where the U.S. became a leading LNG exporter in competition with traditional suppliers like Russia. The U.S. also employed a range of hard and soft power instruments to undermine Russia's energy dominance in Europe. This was increasingly evident from 2014, when the Crimean crisis and subsequent sanctions escalated U.S.-Russia tensions, and the EU openly engaged in discourse to reduce reliance on Russian resources. Despite U.S. efforts to promote its LNG as an alternative to Russian gas, the EU's internal divisions and economic considerations created a complex landscape, with some member states pushing for continued cooperation with Russia. Overall, the U.S. influence on the EU was clearly present, but did not represent a deciding force, rather, an important partner, whose opinion was closely considered.

The study also analyzed the broader implications of American energy policy in global markets. Through the analysis of instruments, research found that energy diplomacy and sanctions have affected international energy markets to a bigger extent. The United States has further employed the exports of energy, particularly LNG, as an

instrument to foster strategic partnerships, reinforce its geopolitical influence, and reduce dependence of the EU on Russian energy. Military power, while historically used by the U.S., has played a less important role in recent years, with the U.S. increasingly relying on economic and diplomatic tools to achieve its strategic objectives.

Historically, the U.S. has used a combination of hard and soft power strategies to secure its position in global energy markets, adjusting its policies to match geopolitical changes and national energy developments. U.S. engagement in energy markets has been particularly pronounced when new geopolitical shifts occur, such as post-2022 EU, or when domestic production shifts, like the shale boom. U.S. policy has evolved with each administration, reflecting the priorities and strategies of the sitting president, with a shift from focusing on energy security to promoting U.S. energy dominance, particularly during strategic crises. Before 2008, U.S. energy policy was centered around military power and economic diplomacy aimed at securing energy resources, especially in the Middle East. The petrodollar system helped ensure global oil transactions were conducted in U.S. dollars, solidifying America's power. These actions laid the groundwork for the U.S.'s eventual leadership in global energy markets. The policy shift toward unconventional energy production began with the Energy Policy Act of 2005, which prioritized the development of shale gas. With the shale revolution, this led the U.S. to promote LNG exports and establish itself as a potential energy supplier to Europe and other markets. At the same time, U.S. sanctions on Iran and Venezuela reinforced American dominance in global energy, while also encouraging EU energy security cooperation. Following Russia's 2014 annexation of Crimea, the U.S. imposed sanctions on Russia's energy sector, reducing its influence over European energy supplies. U.S. LNG exports to the EU increased, capitalizing on Europe's rising demand for alternatives to Russian gas, and the U.S.-EU Energy Council was created to advance

energy diversification and market integration. The Russian Special Military Operation in Ukraine in 2022 marked a major shift, with the U.S. imposing sanctions on Russian energy and becoming the largest LNG supplier to Europe. The EU-U.S. Energy Task Force, formed in 2022, cemented this partnership to ensure Europe's energy security and reduce its dependence on Russian energy. Additionally, the U.S. continued to promote itself as a leader in the green energy transition. The U.S. capitalized on the crisis to strengthen its leadership in the global LNG market while also furthering its role in the global energy transition and decarbonization efforts. LNG exports will remain a dominant force in the EU, but increased domestic natural gas consumption, along with natural limits of U.S. shale production, will likely constrain export capacity. As a result, the global energy market is becoming increasingly multipolar, with regional powers like Russia, China, and India strengthening their influence. This shift opens opportunities for Russia to diversify its production, trade, and alliances.

In conclusion, the hypothesis that the U.S. utilized both hard and soft power to facilitate the EU shift away from Russian energy supplies and that the U.S. benefited most from the reorganization of global energy markets was broadly confirmed. The U.S. influence, while immense, was not purely deterministic, and the EU's internal policy and interests and broader geopolitical forces decided the final outcome of its energy policy. The shift in energy relations has made the U.S. a key player in international energy markets, but with challenges like the rise of new players like China and India, and the enhanced EU emphasis on decarbonization. This research has confirmed that U.S. energy policies have played a transformative role in reshaping global energy flows, the EU's energy strategy, and its relations with Russia.

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